A TIMELINE FROM THE FAMILY PAPERS

Geert Greydanus 1899–1965

A Rotterdam police detective who went into hiding in April 1943 rather than arrest Jews, helped Allied airmen in the Achterhoek as “Oom Geert”, survived Vught, Buchenwald and Niederorschel, and later farmed near Clinton, Ontario.

Overview

Geert Greydanus (1 December 1899 – 14 September 1965) was a Rotterdam police detective. On 9 April 1943 he went into hiding rather than arrest Jews, and he joined the resistance around Varsseveld in the Achterhoek, where he was known as "Oom Geert". He was arrested on 20 April 1944 and survived Vught, Buchenwald and the Niederorschel subcamp. After the war he went back to the police, but he emigrated to Ontario in September 1947 and farmed near Clinton until his death.

This timeline combines three Drive folders: the Greydanus/Walinga family papers (Geert's journal kept by his daughter Wietske, the post-war restoration form, police letters), the Stichting 1940–1945 pension file, Red Cross and Buchenwald records, and family accounts. Those accounts include Jurjen Hoekstra's 2013 *Levensverhaal van Geert Greydanus*, Ben Greydanus's 2025 interview, and Joel Dykstra's school essay about Wietske.

Family at a glance

Geert Greydanus

RELATIONSHIP: Subject

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born Kubaard (Hennaarderadeel), Friesland, 1 Dec 1899; died Clinton, Ont., 14 Sep 1965

Jacobje "Johanna" Pebesma

RELATIONSHIP: Wife

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born Garijp, 22 Apr 1902; married Geert in Heerlen on 9 May 1923

Jacob Greydanus and Saakje Hibma

RELATIONSHIP: Parents

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Geert was the second of 9 children

Wietske

RELATIONSHIP: Daughter

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born Rotterdam, 4 Mar 1924 (Vught card: "Grietje Wietske"); married Dirk Walinga 27 Nov 1948

Jacob (Jaap)

RELATIONSHIP: Son

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born 17 Jan 1927; killed in Pasuruan, Dutch East Indies, 21 Aug 1947

Jan (John)

RELATIONSHIP: Son

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born 4 Jun 1928

Gerard Bouke (Jerry)

RELATIONSHIP: Son

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born 15 Feb 1932

Cornelis Wiebe (Con)

RELATIONSHIP: Son

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born 6 Nov 1936

Bernhard (Ben)

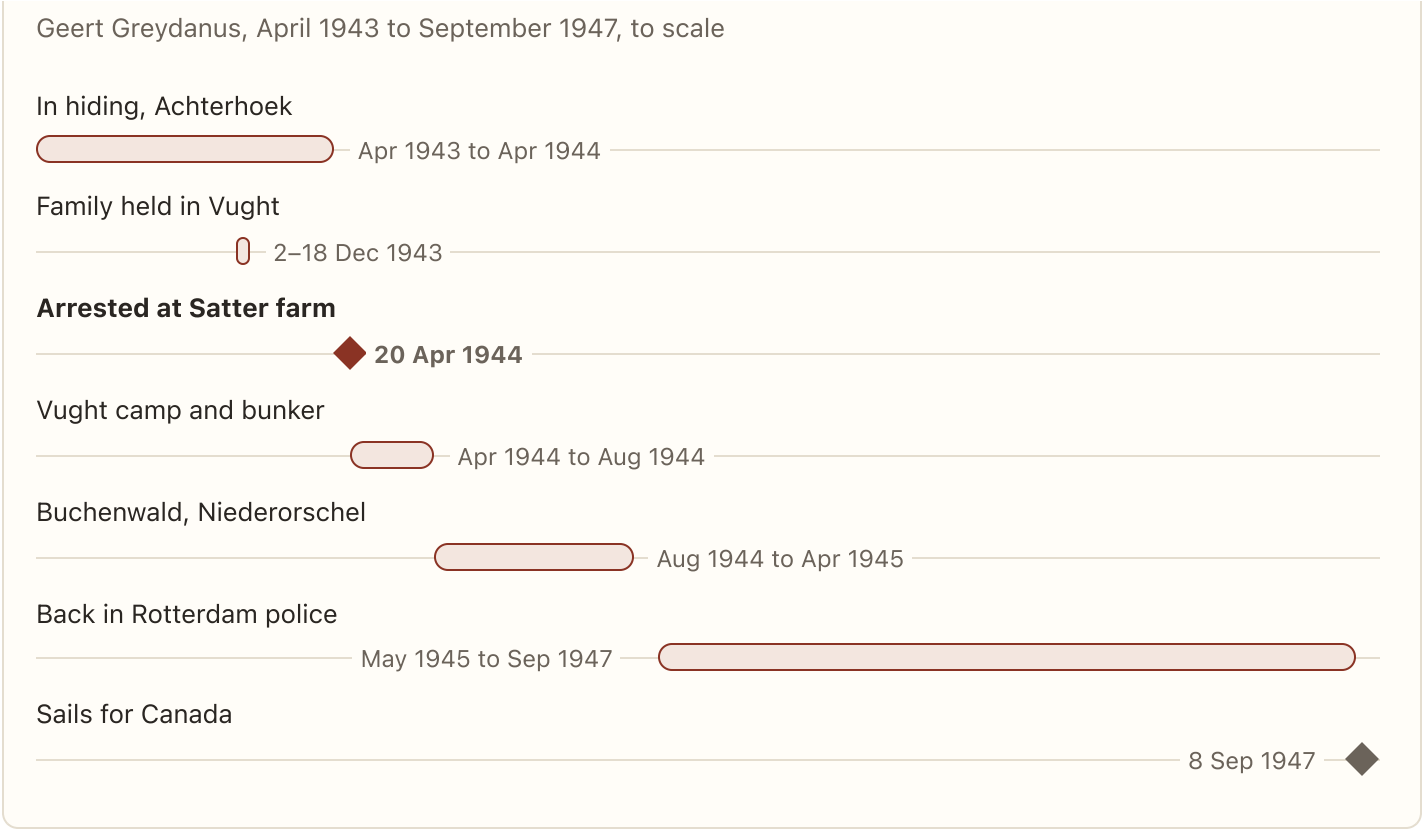
RELATIONSHIP: Son

DATES IN THE PAPERS: Born 6 Oct 1944, while Geert was in Buchenwald

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Family dates: pension decision 1967, police letter 1952, Hoekstra 2013, pp. 2–3, 18, Joel Dykstra essay, Ben interview. Every row below links to the file it came from.

A year in hiding, a year in the camps, two years back in the police



The arrest on 20 April 1944 divides a year in hiding from almost a year in the camps. Dates come from the police, camp and pension records. The family's Vught dates (2–18 Dec 1943) come from the Arolsen hostage cards.

Geert’s journey on a map

From the day he went into hiding to the day he left for Canada.



9 Apr 1943
Rotterdam
Refuses to arrest Jews and goes into hiding, first at an address in Rotterdam. More

12 Apr 1943
Winterswijk
Hides with H. Wiggers at the farm Plak-an near Winterswijk. More

Late Apr 1943 – 20 Apr 1944
Satter farm, Sinderen
A year on Hendrik Satter's farm as “Oom Geert”, helping people in hiding and Allied airmen. He spends about five weeks of it with relatives in Friesland. More

20–21 Apr 1944
Avegoor, Ellecom
Arrested at the farm. The truck takes the prisoners to Avegoor, where they are stripped: “Greydanus was in bad shape”. More

21 Apr 1944
Arnhem
Taken on to the SD (security police) building in Arnhem. More

21 Apr – 9 Aug 1944
Kamp Vught
Held in Kamp Vught and tortured in its bunker, cells 117 and 93. More

9 Aug 1944
Kleve
Sent by train with 15 others to the prison in Kleve, just over the German border. More

15 Aug 1944
Buchenwald
Registered at Buchenwald concentration camp and put in the overcrowded “Little Camp”. More

4 Sep 1944 – 1 Apr 1945
Niederorschel
One of the 100 men who set up the Niederorschel subcamp, working 12-hour days for Langenwerke AG. More

1–11 Apr 1945
Buchenwald
Death march back to Buchenwald; more than 100 of the 525 who set out die. US troops liberate Buchenwald on 11 April. More

8–9 May 1945
Eindhoven
Reaches the reception centre in Eindhoven and sends word to Johanna: “Am well and healthy.” More

12 May 1945
Rotterdam
Home in Rotterdam, “unrecognisable”. Back at work with the police two days later. More

8 Sep 1947
Rotterdam
Sails for Canada with his family on the Tabinta, and farms in Ontario for the rest of his life. More

Lines join the places in the order the records give; they are not the roads or railways he travelled. Positions are the towns, not exact addresses. Borders are today’s, from Natural Earth.

1899–1943: Friesland, Rotterdam and the police

Geert grew up on Frisian farms, served in the military police, and by 1940 was a senior detective with Rotterdam's Centrale Recherche. Rows run oldest first, so the timeline reads in order.

1 Dec 1899

Born in Kubaard (municipality of Hennaarderadeel), Friesland. He was the second of 9 children of Jacob Greydanus and Saakje Hibma

SOURCE: Police letter 26 Sep 1952; Buchenwald cards; Hoekstra 2013, p. 2

c. 1910

Sent at about 10 or 11 to work for the farmer next door "to get rid of a mouth at the table"

SOURCE: Ben interview

1906–1916

Johanna's family (Jan Pebesma and Wietske Baron) works in the mines near Recklinghausen, then moves to the Limburg mines (Treebeek, Brunssum). This is where Johanna learned German

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 3; Ben interview

Before 1923

Military service in the military police, which became his route into the Rotterdam police

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 2

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9 May 1923

Marries Jacobje "Johanna" Pebesma in Heerlen. They met while she was staying with relatives in Friesland

SOURCE: Pension decision 23 Mar 1967; Hoekstra 2013, p. 3

1924–1936

Children born in Rotterdam: Wietske (4 Mar 1924), Jacob (17 Jan 1927), Jan (4 Jun 1928), Gerard Bouke (15 Feb 1932), Cornelis Wiebe (6 Nov 1936)

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 3; Joel Dykstra essay

1930s

Promoted to brigadier, then "majoor", working as a detective with the Centrale Recherche. Ben recalls his insurance-arson sting and his discreet use of clairvoyants on missing-person cases

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 3; Stichting letter (in Verzetsrapport); Ben interview

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17 Dec 1938

Advent meditation clipped from *De Rotterdammer*, later kept folded in his wallet

SOURCE: Papers in Wallet

May 1940

The family, living at West-Varkenoordseweg 359b, witnesses the fighting for the bridges and the bombing of central Rotterdam

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 3

Early 1943

Police leadership announces that taking part in actions ordered by the Germans is compulsory, on pain of dismissal

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 4

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9 Apr 1943

Does not report for duty to arrest Jews and goes into hiding. Joel's essay says only one other officer on the force did the same

SOURCE: Police letter 26 Sep 1952; Police Dismissal translation; Joel essay

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10 Apr 1943

Dismissed as brigadier of the Rotterdam municipal police, with effect from this date

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport

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28 Apr 1943

The Director-General of Police (Hoog-Soeren) sends the written dismissal for "unsuitability", citing his absence on 9 April for the arrest of Jews

SOURCE: Police Dismissal + translation

20–22 Oct 1943

A further decision dismisses him as an unpaid *rijksveldwachter*. Police President J.J. Boelstra sends notice to the family home on 22 Oct

SOURCE: Geert journal p. 6

April 1943 – April 1944: in hiding, "Oom Geert" in the Achterhoek

For a year Geert hid in Winterswijk and then on Hendrik Satter's farm near Sinderen and Varsseveld, where he worked with the local LO (help for people in hiding) and the *Trouw* group. On his signed 1947 government restoration form he gave his cover name as "**de Boer Gerrit**". The group knew him as "Oom Geert", although the 1952 Stichting report types it as "Oom Gerrit" (see *Pseudonyms: exact wording*).

9–12 Apr 1943

First hiding place, in Rotterdam: "aan de Sikemstraat [?] 14 p/a of ten huize van M. Berlijn" (the street name is hard to read)

SOURCE: Geert form p. 1

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12 Apr – late Apr 1943

Hides "bij H. Wiggers, hoeve Plak-an te Winterswijk"

SOURCE: Geert form p. 1; Verzetsrapport; J. Satter letter 1952

Late Apr 1943 – 20 Apr 1944

Hides with the H. Satter family between Sinderen and Varsseveld, apart from about 5 weeks with relatives in Friesland. The farm was a resistance centre: Satter co-founded the local *Trouw* distribution and sometimes sheltered more than 30 people in hiding. A 2014 Trouw article by Meindert van der Kaaij, based on Willemien (Wil) Satter's memories, says the first LO meeting was held on the farm and that Trouw's leadership met there regularly after the paper was founded in Aerdenhout on 30 Jan 1943 (Trouw, text read from Jared's blog copy). Hoekstra adds that neither Wil nor Geert was allowed into those meetings: "De dochter van Hendrik Satter, Wil, mocht niet aanwezig zijn bij deze vergaderingen, evenmin als Geert Greydanus" (Hoekstra 2013, p. 5)

SOURCE: Geert form p. 1; Hoekstra 2013, pp. 4–7; Hendrik Satter, Oorlogsgravenstichting

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1943–1944

Lives under the cover name "de Boer Gerrit geb. 1-9-97 te Leeuwarden" (his own signed declaration). Schaap adds that he carried a false Rotterdam police ID (P.B.). Exact quotes are under Pseudonyms: exact wording

SOURCE: Geert form p. 4, section V; Schaap account, NIOD 251a

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1943–1944

As "Oom Geert" he helps the Varsseveld group and the LO: placing people in hiding, arranging meetings, sheltering downed Allied pilots and distributing illegal newspapers. He also leads Sunday services for the people hiding on the farm

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport; Satter letter; SEV report; Hoekstra 2013, p. 7

1943–1944

By his own account to Ben, he worked as the underground's "internal detective", tracing who was skimming stolen ration coupons. He carried a revolver and three sets of false ID, and helped run a sting that exposed two German sympathisers

SOURCE: Ben interview

1943–1944

Visits Johanna's Baron relatives in Suawoude, Friesland, sometimes disguised as an old farmer. Leni de Beer, a Jewish teacher from Rotterdam, hid from spring 1943 with Johanna's uncle and aunt, Jurjen and Jeltje Baron, in Suawoude. Yad Vashem says only: "During her years in Rotterdam, she had become acquainted with a Mister Baron, who had early on mentioned that she could count on his family in case of need." No source names Geert as the link. Hoekstra suspects it ("possible, Geert Greydanus played a role here") but concludes it was "niet bevestigd" (not confirmed). If Geert was the link, he had good reason to keep it hidden

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 1, 7, 20; Hoekstra Yad Vashem report

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7 Nov (year unclear)

Clandestine sermon "De vluchteling in zijn schuilplaats" (no. 4), with a typed warning to people in hiding: "HOOR, ZIE maar ZWIJG!" Geert kept it in his wallet

SOURCE: Papers in Wallet

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1 Dec 1943

Johanna and the four younger children are taken hostage, questioned at the police station and SS headquarters, then taken to Kamp Vught. Wietske keeps the older children's camp numbers

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 6; Geert journal p. 3a

Dec 1943

Geert panics and wants to give himself up. Satter and Anne Schaap talk him out of it and take him to Schaap's parents' farm in Beetgum, Friesland, for a few weeks

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 6; Ben interview

7–15 Dec 1943

Letters to and from Vught. On 7 Dec a helper reports seeing Cornelis and bringing a St Nicholas gift. On 12 Dec Wietske (prisoner 0667, Block 24) writes home asking for food and sweaters. On 15 Dec a letter gives the numbers: Johanna 0666, Wietske 0667, Jacob (16) 8426, Jan (15) 8428

SOURCE: Geert journal 1and2, 1b, 1a translation, 3a, 4a

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18 Dec 1943

Rauter releases the police officers' families "in view of the coming Christmas season". The Vught index cards date it exactly. Johanna's reads "Greydanus geb. Pebesma, Jacobje … Gijz. 0666 … Garijp … met 2 kinderen … Binnengekomen: 2 Dec. 1943, Vrijgelaten 18 Dec. 1943" (Arolsen 360367, file 360366). Wietske's card, as "Greydanus, Grietje Wietske … Gijz. 0667 … Rotterdam, 4 Maart 1924", gives the same "Binnengekomen: 2 Dec 1943" and "vrijgelaten 18 Dec. 1943" (Arolsen 360364). "Gijz." means gijzelaar, hostage. Johanna takes the youngest children to Geert's family in Anjum. Jacob and Jan go to Lammert and Romkje Baron in Suawoude

SOURCE: Rauter note no. 406/1943 + translation; Hoekstra 2013, p. 6

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29 Dec 1943

The Rotterdam Police President circulates Rauter's note: officers in hiding who report before early January 1944 may return to service. Geert does not

SOURCE: Rauter note translation

1943–1944

Colleagues L. Kits and Th. v. Bliemen pass on f 300 to the family (around Nov 1944). Separately, after his dismissal, the Gereformeerde Kerk deacons pay the family f 3,662.70

SOURCE: Geert form p. 6; Context doc (journal 3–4)

Spring 1944

Ordered to work for the *Trouw* group in Friesland. In March 1944 he helps Theo van Braak with downed pilots

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport; Braak-Raterink letter

The Gerstein report in the chicken coop

A month before Geert came to Hendrik Satter's farm, one of the first eyewitness accounts of the Nazi gas chambers was written out in its farmhouse and hidden in its chicken coop. It lay there, under a roof tile, for the whole year Geert hid on the farm. The witness was Kurt Gerstein, an SS officer. He never came to Sinderen himself: his account reached the farm through two Dutchmen, a friend of his in Doesburg and a resistance man from Geert's own network.

No source says Geert saw the document or knew it was there. This section tells its story because it happened on the farm and among the people he lived with, and because it is about the fate he refused to help bring on Rotterdam's Jews.

Who Kurt Gerstein was

Gerstein was born in Münster, Germany, on 11 August 1905 and trained as a mining engineer. He was a committed Protestant, active in church youth work and in the Confessing Church, the part of the German Protestant church that resisted Nazi control. In 1936 he was arrested for sending out anti-Nazi religious pamphlets and expelled from the Nazi party; in July 1938 he was held for about six weeks in the Welzheim camp.

In February 1941 his sister-in-law, Berta Ebeling, died at Hadamar, one of the hospitals where the Nazi "euthanasia" programme killed psychiatric patients. In March 1941 Gerstein joined the Waffen-SS. He later said he joined to see from the inside what was being done and to tell the world; historians note that he had applied before Berta's death, and his motives are still debated. Part of his basic training was in Arnhem, and while he was there he looked up an old friend from a Christian student association, the Dutch engineer J.H. (Herman) Ubbink, who ran an iron foundry in Doesburg.

Because he knew about disinfection, the SS posted him to its Hygiene Institute in Berlin, where he dealt with Zyklon B, the poison gas also used at Auschwitz. In August 1942 he was sent to the extermination camps of Belzec and Treblinka in occupied Poland, to change their gas chambers from engine exhaust to cyanide. At Belzec he watched the gassing of a transport of Jews from Lwów, from their arrival by train to their burial. The change he was sent to make was never carried out. On the train back to Berlin he told a Swedish diplomat, Baron Göran von Otter, everything he had seen, and in the months that followed he tried to tell the papal nuncio in Berlin, Swiss diplomats and Protestant church leaders.

What the "Gerstein Report" is

In April 1945 Gerstein gave himself up to the French army in Reutlingen. Held in Rottweil, he wrote down his account in French and then twice in German (April–May 1945). These statements are what historians call the **Gerstein Report**. A French version was used as evidence at the Nuremberg trials (document PS-1553), and it is still one of the most quoted descriptions of how the gas chambers of Belzec and Treblinka worked. Historians treat it as a genuine eyewitness account, though some of its numbers are too high; the historian Florent Brayard argues that those numbers are what the camp commanders boasted to Gerstein at the time.

The French moved Gerstein to the Cherche-Midi military prison in Paris as a suspected war criminal. He was found dead in his cell on 25 July 1945; the official finding was suicide, though some suspect he was murdered. In 1950 a German denazification court in Tübingen classed him as an offender because of the Zyklon B he had supplied. In January 1965 the state of Baden-Württemberg cleared his name. His story is told in Rolf Hochhuth's 1963 play *The Deputy*, which opens with Gerstein pleading with the papal nuncio, and in Costa-Gavras's 2002 film *Amen.*

How his account reached the Satter farm

1. **Berlin, February 1943.** Ubbink visited Gerstein in Berlin and found him in despair. Ubbink later wrote: "He asked me if I could get in touch with people who had radio contact with London. I told him I could. He asked me, no — more than that, he begged me to transmit this story to England, so it would be known all over the world, and that the German people could be warned." (Brayard, p. 161)

2. **Doesburg.** Ubbink's foundry was a distribution point for the underground papers *Vrij Nederland* and *Trouw*. He passed Gerstein's account to a resistance man he knew only as "Cor": Cornelis van der Hooft from Overschie, Rotterdam, the chief distributor of the illegal papers in the Achterhoek and one of the early *Trouw* men. Twenty years later Ubbink recognised him from a photograph: "We called him Cor." (Van Kaam 1995; Hoekstra 2013, pp. 22–23)

3. **The Satter farmhouse, 25 March 1943.** Van der Hooft came to the farm in Sinderen and wrote out a four-page Dutch version, headed *Tötungsanstalten in Polen* ("Killing installations in Poland"), with Hendrik Satter and his son Jo watching. Jo remembered: "I can still see Cor sitting there writing. He was actually completely shaken by it. ...

When Cor was finished, he said: 'This is such a terrible thing; you must read this.'" (Van Kaam 1995; Brayard places the meeting "in the outskirts of Doesburg", p. 163)

4. **The chicken coop.** Jo's sister Willemien, then 21, overheard them: "They did not know what to do with it. I heard them say 'unbelievable' a few times. They thought it might be a trap. Could the writer be trusted, and if so, were he and his family safe, because he could easily be recognised from the report? In the end I heard Jo say: 'put it away in the chicken coop.'" (Trouw, 30 Jan 2014, translated) The plan was to get the officer and his family into hiding first, with the Satters finding an address, and only then publish. Van der Hooft went to take that message back to Ubbink, but never came back for the document. (Hoekstra 2013, p. 23)

5. **London, April–September 1943.** The account did reach the Dutch government in exile. A typed version almost identical to the farm's, marked "Rappt. Nr. 61", arrived in London around 24 April 1943, probably by radio. The minister of war, Van Lidth de Jeude, copied it into his diary on 8 May, and in August 1943 the government passed it to the Inter-Allied Information Committee in New York to be published. There is no sign that it ever was. The London copy was only found in 1992. (Brayard, pp. 164–166)

The report and Geert

- **The timing.** The report was written on 25 March 1943. Two weeks later, on 9 April, Geert went into hiding rather than arrest Jews in Rotterdam, and by late April he was living on the Satter farm. The document stayed under the roof tile until after the war. *Interpretation, not a source:* what Geert refused to take part in is what the report describes.
- **Cor van der Hooft was part of Geert's network.** His US Army helper file shows he helped Allied airmen, known to them as "Cor"; his widow named Hendrik Satter and Anne Schaap as the people who could vouch for him. He was arrested on 17 April 1944, three days before the farm was raided and Geert, Hendrik Satter and Schaap were taken (NARA helper file; see the airman-helping network). Shot in the legs while trying to escape, he was later taken to Sachsenhausen, near Oranienburg. In April 1945, when the prisoners were marched away, he could not walk, and the SD shot him by the side of the road. His widow gave his death as 22 April 1945. (Van Kaam 1995)
- **Geert was kept out of it.** Hoekstra writes that Geert was not allowed into the *Trouw* meetings at the farm (Hoekstra 2013, p. 5). That fits the resistance rule Willemien describes: the less you knew, the less you could give away under torture.

After the war

The farmhouse burned down on Good Friday, 30 March 1945, the day Sinderen was liberated, but the chicken coop survived. Jo Satter lifted the roof tile and found the document. He kept it among his papers until 22 November 1966, when he saw a rerun of Lou de Jong's television series *De Bezetting* (The Occupation) and sent De Jong a copy. De Jong, the leading Dutch historian of the war, used it in a 1967 lecture to argue that even brave resistance workers could not bring themselves to believe the news of the gas chambers. Jo Satter always disagreed: they believed it, he said, but the man who gave it to them had to be got to safety first. (Van Kaam 1995; Brayard, pp. 163–164)

Gerstein never learned what had happened to it. A letter he wrote to Ubbink in 1945, a few weeks before he died, found among his belongings after his death, ends: "Ask your people if they at least believe now what happened in Belzec!" (Van Kaam 1995)

Today Van der Hooft's handwritten original is at the Herinneringscentrum Kamp Westerbork, given by the journalist Ben van Kaam, who had it from Jo Satter. The typed London copy is in the Nationaal Archief in The Hague. (Hoekstra 2013, p. 23, quoting *De Gelderlander*, 5 May 2012) Brayard's article prints the full report in English (pp. 174 ff.).

Sources for Gerstein's life outside the Netherlands: United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "Kurt Gerstein"; JTA, 1965, on his rehabilitation; Brayard 2000.

The airman-helping network around Varsseveld (Jan–May 1944)

Two sets of records describe the Varsseveld group that sheltered Allied airmen in the months before Geert's arrest: the evader database of the Studiegroep Luchtoorlog (SGLO), and the US Army's 1945–46 helper files ("Vragenlijst voor helpers van Geallieerd personeel", National Archives RG 498, series *Case Files of Dutch Citizens Proposed for Awards for Assisting American Airmen*). **Geert is not named in any of them.** No helper file exists under Greydanus, Greidanus or Greijdanus, and the helper lists filled in by Hendrik and Jo Satter, Anne Schaap and Theo van Braak's widow do not mention him. They do show the people he lived and worked among, and they tie the 20 April 1944 raid on the Satter farm to the hiding of an American airman.

4–6 Jan 1944

2/Lt. Ford W. Babcock, bombardier of a B-17, lands near Sinderen. Marechaussees C.C. Poulie and W. Helmink spirit him away and bring him to the Satter farm. Jo Satter: "4th Jan 1944 C.C. Pouli and W Helmink came to us with the American flyer Ford William Babcock. After having slept and received following clothes: 1 suit, 1 overcoat and overall, the flyer was brought by A. Schaap and W. Helmink and me to G.H. Hofs, C 345, Varsseveld, because the S.D. was searching in our neighbourhood." Schaap lists Babcock as hidden 4–6 Jan 1944

SOURCE: Jo Satter helper file; Anne Schaap helper file; SGLO E0244

Jan 1944 (cause of 20 Apr arrest)

Hendrik Satter's own form: "Het verbergen van de piloot was de oorzaak van mijn arrestatie. De S.D. heeft mijn vee enz. in beslag genomen." Jo Satter: "On 20th April my father was arrested therefore; until the liberation he was at Siegburg (Dld) concentration-camp." A 1946 claim form adds: "Spent 2 months in Vught, 2 mo. in Utrecht, a week in Via Kleef and 9 mo. in Sieg[b]urg." This does not contradict the Willy Markus betrayal; it says what the SD was looking for

SOURCE: Hendrik Satter helper file, pp. 4–6; Jo Satter helper file, pp. 2, 8

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18 Feb – c. 1 Mar 1944

W/O Albert W. Bennett, RAF, shot down near Diepenveen, is brought by train to Varsseveld, "possibly Th. van Braak (C372 at Varsseveld)", then handed to G.C. Slotboom, who hides him "in a hut in the woods (constructed by R. Knottnerus from Varsseveld)". Schaap's list: Bennett received from "Mees-Diepenveen", passed to "Th.C.v.Braak, later aan H. Leemrijse, Lichtenvoorde". Bennett reached Switzerland on 8 April

SOURCE: SGLO E0294; Schaap helper file, p. 4; van Braak helper file

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23 Mar – early Apr 1944

2/Lt. Robert Donovan and 2/Lt. William Weeks (B-17, crashed near Zelhem) are picked up by Slotboom, van Braak and Helmink and hidden 9 days. Schaap names the escort to Rotterdam: "A. Scholts, Ebenhaëzerstr. 116b, Rotterdam" (SGLO's "Scholz or Schalz"). In Rotterdam they hid at Mathenesserweg 118B. This is the closest the network comes to Geert's own Rotterdam connections, but the escort is named and it is not Geert

SOURCE: Schaap helper file, p. 4; SGLO E0399; van Braak helper file, p. 10

24–25 Mar 1944

Lancaster ME684 crashes near Varsseveld; four crew evade through the Aalten group (Ket, Wikkerink, Leemreize, Lelivelt, ter Haar). A busy fortnight for the whole district a month before the raid

SOURCE: SGLO E0417, E0419

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1 May 1944

Theo van Braak is arrested, eleven days after Geert. His widow: "My man has been arrested 1st May 1944 because of helping flyers. He died in a German concentration-camp for exhaustion." Jo Satter lists him as "murdered by the Germans" and Poulie as "shot 6th June 1944"

SOURCE: van Braak helper file, p. 5; Jo Satter helper file, p. 2

The group as the helpers listed it. Jo Satter (17 Aug 1945): "Th.C. van Braak, C 272, Varsseveld, murdered by the Germans; W. Hofs, C 345, Varsseveld, missed, probably also killed; C.C. Pouli, Varsseveld, shot 6th June 1944; A. Schaap, C 272, Varsseveld; W. Helmink, C 133, Varsseveld; G.C. Slotboom, Doetichemscheweg, Varsseveld; H. Leemreize, Lichtenvoorde; H. Satter, C 99, Varsseveld." Anne Schaap (16 Aug 1945) adds M. v. Prooyen (C 28) and Mej. D. Lammers (Spoorstraat), and says he always worked with "J. Satter, W. Hofs, C.C. Poulie, W. Helmink en Th.C.v.Braak, en later ook met G.C. Slotboom". All give their movement as *Trouw* / LO / KP Varsseveld.

A question these files raise. Anne Schaap's form (born "8-7-'19 Leeuwarden") says: "Tengevolge van mijn illegaal werk, waaronder ook piloten hulp, heb ik 1½ jaar moeten onderduiken." The timeline above has him arrested with Geert and Satter on 20 April 1944 (NIOD 251a; Geert's 1945 form). He does not mention an arrest here, so he may have escaped or been released soon after. Worth checking.

What the other helper files add

The remaining Varsseveld-area files in the same series were read too. None names Geert, Greydanus or "Oom Geert". What they add:

- **Cor van der Hooft, arrested three days before the raid.** Cornelis Adriana van der Hooft of Delftweg 30, Overschie (Rotterdam), known to the airmen as "Cor", member of "Leeuwengarde and Trouw". His widow, 19 June 1946: "died in concentration camp Sacksenhausen 22-4-45. Arrested on 17-4-44." Among the people who could vouch for him she lists "H. Satter and A. Schaap, Varsseveld C 99". Her handwritten draft adds that

he worked with "Dr. Arie Speelman" and sent drawings of the harbour of Terneuzen to the Allies. He is the Cor van der Hooft of the 2014 *Trouw* article who stood in the Satter kitchen. His arrest in Rotterdam on 17 April 1944, three days before the Satter farm was surrounded, is a new lead for the chain of arrests, and Geert had been to Rotterdam on the 20th. (NAID 286702134)

- **Willy Markus confirmed by a second helper.** H.J.A. Leemreize ("Piet", Lichtenvoorde), 1945: "By treachery of Willy Markens several workers have been shot or killee in battles", listing "Cees Pauli, Marechausse Varsseveld, shot" among them. A US Army note in his file records him receiving "pilots from Mr. W. Helmink at Varsseveld. The first time, two pilots on 5 January 1944" (Babcock's group). (NAID 286671112, pp. 8, 10)
- **G.H. Hofs, the next house after the Satters.** Gerrit Hendrik Hofs, Aaltenscheweg C 345, sheltered Babcock on 5–6 January 1944 ("J. Satter, A. Schaap, my son Willem Hofs and W. Helmink" brought him; passed on to "H. Leemreize, Lichtenvoorde"). He was arrested too: "I have been arrested because I housed the on other side mentioned flyer by the S.D., but I did the fool and said that my son had done the work." His son Willem, the leader of the group, was "still missing: he was 1½ year in a concentrationcamp". (NAID 286661150)
- **Willem Helmink**, marechaussee, Doetinchemsestraat C 133: Babcock was taken by the Feldgendarmerie to the town hall and "In samenwerking met één der politie beambten (Poulie) hebben we hem laten ontvluchten. Poulie is ondergedoken, één maand later gegrepen door S.D en ... gefusilleerd (6 Juni 44)." His helper list is the fullest: Leemreize, van Braak, Schaap, R. Knottnerus, H. Becking, Th. van Prooyen, J. Satter, G.H. Hofs, D. Lammers, G.C. Slotboom, G.H. Weenink, G. Hiddink, H. Gussinklo. (NAID 286659333)
- **R.B. (Riep) Knottnerus**, who built the hut in the woods: Bennett stayed "± een week" in "een huisje van mij in een bos in Sinderen bij Varsseveld". (NAID 286667652)
- **Dien Lammers**, Spoorstraat C 69, hid Donovan and Weeks for 9 days from 23 March 1944 and passed them to "P. Scholtz, Rotterdam". (NAID 286670537)
- **G.W. Gussinklo**, D 314 Sinderen, hid "twee geallieerde vliegeniers" for one day in March 1944 and gave each a coat; handed to Slotboom, Helmink and van Braak. (NAID 286657435)
- **A caution on G.C. Slotboom.** He claimed 23 evaders. The US Army later wrote that "Further investigation in the light of newly received information proves his story to be almost entirely false. He actually transported perhaps two pilots over short distances",

and downgraded him. SGLO's accounts of Bennett and Donovan rely partly on his file, so treat his role there with care. (NAID 286689024, p. 4)

Why Geert is absent is not explained. These forms were filled in during August 1945, when Geert was back in Rotterdam, and each helper listed only fellow airman-helpers; Geert's own forms describe him as a policeman in hiding, not an airman helper. The "helps Theo van Braak with downed pilots" entry above still rests on family sources alone.

A full-text hit for "Greidanus" in the series is a different man: "Idema Greidanus", a paratrooper "killed in action", in the file of J.J. Lowey Ball of Delft (NAID 286672718).

The betrayal: Willy Markus

The raid on the Satter farm on 20 April 1944 was one of many that day across the Achterhoek, all set off by Willy Markus, an informer for the German security police (the SD) who had spent three months inside the local resistance. The LO-LKP's own report on Varsseveld puts it plainly: "Willie Marcus ... The entire group of 'Black Kees' trusted him. On April 20, 1944, he struck. On that date, 3 persons were taken away here, namely Satter, Greydanus, and Schaap" (NIOD 251a inv. 20, scan 138, English rendering of the Dutch OCR). The Germans had a name for the Satter house: "het Broeinest", the hotbed (Oorlogsgravenstichting, Hendrik Satter).

Who Willy Markus was

Willem (Willy) Markus was born in Ambt Doetinchem on 24 March 1902. When the war began he ran the café his late father had built up at Hommelstraat 22 in Arnhem. It became a meeting place for black marketeers and German soldiers, and Markus bought drink for the German army and resold it at a profit. In 1943 he was jailed for receiving stolen goods, and came out as a *V-Mann*, a paid informer, for the SD. He learned the work from another Arnhem man, Johnny de Droog. (Wikipedia NL; Oorlogsbronnen)

How he worked, January – April 1944

- **Arnhem jail.** His first job was to befriend a warder who smuggled notes out of the Arnhem prison for resistance prisoners. Markus and De Droog read the notes before

they were delivered, and in January 1944 fourteen people were arrested in Velp and Rheden. (Wikipedia NL)

- "**Willy van Erp**". In January 1944, under that name, he made contact with Gerrit van den Boogerd ("Oom Gert"), who led a military resistance group of more than 500 men. He passed himself off as a secret agent of the Dutch government in London. He won trust by bringing weapons, among them a carbine he put in the hands of Cornelis Ruizendaal ("Zwarte Kees"), leader of the Aalten knokploeg (KP), the armed squad. Because the Germans controlled some of London's radio links, he could even have agreed phrases broadcast on Radio Oranje. (*Het Grote Gebod*, pp. 482–484; Wikipedia NL)
- **Kees Poulie of Varsseveld.** Poulie was a police sergeant at the Varsseveld post who worked with the LO and spread *Trouw*. On 4 January 1944 he helped Lt. Ford W. Babcock, an American airman who had come down near Sinderen, escape from the Germans, and went into hiding himself. He brought Babcock to the Satter farm that day; because the SD was searching the neighbourhood, Babcock was moved on to the Hofs farm next door (see the airman-helping network). Markus offered Poulie and his fiancée, Anna Droog, a way to England through a Belgian escape line. He met them in Zutphen on 8 March and had them arrested at Oosterbeek station the next morning. They were held in Kleve, then in the Vught bunker. A German police court in Vught sentenced Poulie to death on 2 June, and he was shot in the dunes at Overveen on 6 June 1944. (Westland, *Marechaussee Contact*, Oct 2020) What the SD got from his interrogation went onto its list of names (Wikipedia NL). *Interpretation, not a source:* Poulie knew the Satter and Hofs farms from the Babcock affair, which may be how the SD came to them.

20 April 1944

The SD struck on 20 April, a day before Zwarte Kees planned to attack the home-guard post in Ruurlo where Markus lodged. In the morning Markus picked up Van den Boogerd and his deputy Dick Vermeij, who were arrested first. He then drove a borrowed lorry to Beltrum to collect four KP men for a "weapons delivery". They grew suspicious when they saw blood on the floor of the lorry and got out at Doesburg. Two of them were caught at Ellecom; Zwarte Kees was killed in a gunfight in Doesburg. The chemist who had sheltered them, Philippus Gastelaars, was arrested at his shop in Doesburg and shot the next day, 21 April, at the Avegoor SS school in Ellecom (Oorlogsgravenstichting). In the afternoon the raids followed in Aalten, Eibergen, Lichtenvoorde, Lintvelde, Neede and Varsseveld. (Wikipedia NL; *Het Grote Gebod*, p. 484)

The next day 27 prisoners were sent from Arnhem to Vught. Four of them jumped from the lorry on the way, as the timeline's 20–21 April entry also records. Of the rest, about half died before a firing squad or in the camps; 22 men, ten of them from the Achterhoek, were shot at Overveen on 6 June 1944. A second wave of arrests followed on 30 April and 1 May. In all, more than 70 people fell victim to Markus's betrayal, and at least 28 of them did not survive. (Wikipedia NL; Westland 2020) A US Army helper file from Lichtenvoorde names him too: "By treachery of Willy Markens several workers have been shot" (Leemreize helper file).

After the war

Once the Achterhoek knew who had betrayed it, Markus was of no more use there. After a failed attempt in Roermond to trap a resistance leader who in turn hoped to kidnap him, he asked to be sent to work in Germany. After the war he feigned insanity and spent a long time in psychiatric institutions. On 5 July 1949 the Bijzonder Gerechtshof (special court) in Arnhem sentenced him to life imprisonment. The sentence was later cut to 18 years: in October 1950 according to Westland, in December 1952 according to Wikipedia. Westland adds that a further year was taken off in 1954. He was released in 1956 and died in Enschede on 24 March 1978. (Oorlogsbronnen; Wikipedia NL; Westland 2020)

What this adds for Geert

- **Markus's trial files are identified.** The CABR (the archive of post-war collaboration cases at the Nationaal Archief) holds two files on Willem Markus of Arnhem: inventory number 66972 (file 1851), on paper and readable only in The Hague, and inventory number 188 (file 350/49), which is scanned and readable in the digital CABR at the Nationaal Archief and other reading rooms. The bodies involved were the special court and prosecutor in Arnhem, the Bijzondere Raad van Cassatie (the appeal court) and the political investigation service in Doetinchem. (Oorlog voor de Rechter) Such files often list the people a traitor gave up, and may show why the SD came to the Satter farm.
- **A possible second informer.** The same LO-LKP Varsseveld report says: "There must have been another traitor hiding in Varsseveld, but this never came out. It was a certain 'Cor'. Under J. de Drooge, three worked in the Achterhoek, in Varsseveld Cor." It goes on to link a "Heezen", also called Cor Arends, to the arrest of the Jolink sisters, who hid Jews. (NIOD 251a inv. 20, scan 138, English rendering) Not identified; worth a search in the CABR index.
- **Geert's 1943 host was a different Wiggers.** *Het Grote Gebod* lists "Hendrik Wiggers (Oom Henk)" among Markus's victims: Hendrik Jan Wiggers of Vellegendijk 17, Aalten,

who hid a Jewish family and died at Mittelbau-Dora in February 1945 (Synagoge Aalten; Oorlogsbronnen). Geert's second hiding place, "bij H. Wiggers, hoeve Plak-an te Winterswijk", was another family's farm: Plakan, near the Bumerweg on the edge of Winterswijk, where the Jasmijnlaan now runs. Hans Wiggers (about 1911–2005) farmed there and sheltered Jews from Winterswijk and others until the end of the war; Yad Vashem honoured him on 10 October 1979. He came through the war unharmed. (OudWinterswijk; Achterhoek Nieuws, 4 May 2020)

- **Reading to follow up.** Henny Bennink, "Verzetsman Hendrikus (Hendrik) Johannes Antonius Leemreize 1909–1994", *De Lichte Voorde* 46 (June 2002), pp. 20–41, covers Poulie, Babcock and the events of 20 April. The books cited by Wikipedia may say more about Varsseveld: Bennink, *Bezetting en verzet* (2005), and Erik Schaap, *De levens van Johnny de Droog* (2020).

April – August 1944: arrest, the Vught bunker, transport

On 20 April 1944 the SD raided the Satter farm after the agent provocateur Willy Markus betrayed resistance groups across the Achterhoek. Geert spent nearly four months in Vught, was tortured in the camp bunker, and held to the story that he was only a conscientious objector, never part of the resistance.

20 Apr 1944

The farm is surrounded. Geert, Hendrik Satter and Anne Schaap are arrested (Hoekstra says they were listening to the BBC). Geert had been to Rotterdam that day and had just come back from Varsseveld station. Ben says he had a premonition and threw his revolver and false IDs into the outhouse. The LO-LKP's Varsseveld report names the three: "On April 20, 1944, he struck. On that date, 3 persons were taken away here, namely Satter, Greydanus, and Schaap" (archieven.nl English rendering; Dutch original not yet checked) (NIOD 251a inv. 20, scan 138)

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport; Hoekstra 2013, p. 8; Ben interview; Willy Markus (Wikipedia NL)

20–21 Apr 1944

The truck picks up Blaauwgeers and others in Lichtenvoorde, then goes to Avegoor (Ellecom), where prisoners are stripped and "Greydanus was in bad shape", and on to the SD building in Arnhem. Several prisoners escape on the way to Vught

SOURCE: Schaap account, NIOD 251a pp. 7–8; KP-Aalten (Wikipedia NL)

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1 May 1944

Theo van Braak, the Varsseveld teacher Geert helped with pilots in March, is arrested in Varsseveld eleven days after Geert. He ends up in the Vught bunker; his camp card reads "Cel 93 / Bunker", the cell the Red Cross gives for Geert from early July. He is on Geert's transport out of Vught and dies at Gross-Rosen (Striegau) on 31 Dec 1944

SOURCE: Oorlogsbronnen: T.C. van Braak; Arolsen 342011; HGG II necrology; train note

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21 Apr – 9 Aug 1944

Held in Kamp Vught. He is tortured in the bunker; Hoekstra names the interrogators v.d. Berg, Enkelstrodt, Wemelink and "bunker executioner" Popey. Ben describes beatings over a chair and alternating ice-cold and near-boiling baths. A fellow bunker prisoner, J. v.d. Hauw of Spannum, wrote on 16 Jun 1945 to a "Mevrouw Heinen" (possibly the wife of the Henk Heinen in Schaap's account) about her husband's arrival in the bunker "met de anderen uit Neede". He says a Willem [surname unclear] "kwam vlak naast Greydanus te zitten in een cel recht tegenover mijn cel" (came to sit right next to Greydanus, in a cell directly opposite mine) (NIOD 251a inv. 325, scan 56)

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport; Police letter 1952; Hoekstra 2013, p. 8; Ben interview

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21 Apr – 9 Aug 1944 (cells)

The Netherlands Red Cross summary of his own post-war statements: he "was held in the concentration camp Vught, from April 21 to 8 or 9 July in cel 117, then to August 9 in cel 93. On August 9 he was taken to the prison in Cleef" (Kleve). The 2015 family timeline puts the move into cell 117 on 27 Apr 1944

SOURCE: Red Cross letter (drs. M. Schwartzenberg), transcribed in the Geert Greydanus Timeline doc

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6 Jun 1944

The Achterhoek group, including Jo Blaauwgeers, Gerrit Kleisen and Kees Poulie, is executed in the dunes at Overveen. Geert is classed as a political prisoner instead

SOURCE: Schaap account; Jo Blaauwgeers; Hoekstra 2013, p. 8

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c. 22 Jun 1944

A German-language appeal to Reichskommissar Seyss-Inquart, written about 9 weeks after the arrest: Vught says he is in a section without numbers, and a parcel has come back unopened

SOURCE: Geert journal 7a; 7 translated en

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9 Aug 1944

Leaves Vught on a transport with about 15 others, "I think to Kleve". A fellow prisoner writes to Johanna that Geert asks her to stay strong "in view of the increase in your family". The Buchenwald effects card later records his belongings coming "v. Haftanst. Kleve" (Arolsen 6004388). Hendrik Satter, held in Kleve later that month, confirms it: "Greydanus was also in Kleve"

SOURCE: Geert journal 13and14, 14b; Satter in Schaap account; NIOD 251a inv. 20, scan 140

9–15 Aug 1944 (his own words)

Geert's 1945 Red Cross form: "In Vught gevangenis van 21-4 tot 9-8-1944 in No. Cel 117 en vanaf 8 of 9 Juli Cel [93]" and then, on 9 Aug, "met eenige [mann]en en vrouwen (16 in totaal) per trein naar Cleef". He reached Buchenwald on 15 Aug, "ik als eenigste van dat transport in Buchenw." (I as the only one of that transport in Buchenwald). So the others on the Kleve transport, Theo van Braak among them, went elsewhere. (Part of this passage is torn or stained; the words in brackets are reconstructions)

SOURCE: Red Cross form, Greydanus 1a

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9 Aug 1944

The day Geert leaves Vught, his fellow prisoner Jacob (Jaap) Stigter, 20, of KP-Neede, is shot in the camp. Stigter had been arrested in the Achterhoek (the museum gives 20 April or 24 May 1944) with the doctor who treated his wound. The v.d. Hauw letter above places "de anderen uit Neede" in the bunker near Greydanus

SOURCE: NMK Vught: Stigter, Jacob; NIOD 251a inv. 325, scan 56

Aug 1944

Throws a pencilled note from the train: Greydanus, Franssen of Rotterdam and Van Braak of Varsseveld "are doing well". A stranger posts it to West-Varkenoordseweg 359b

SOURCE: Geert journal p. 8, 13and14; Hoekstra 2013, p. 8; Ben interview

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August 1944 – May 1945: Buchenwald, Niederorschel and liberation

Geert was Buchenwald political prisoner **no. 5892**. Within three weeks he was sent to the Niederorschel subcamp, where prisoners made Junkers aircraft parts. He survived the April 1945 death march back to Buchenwald and was liberated there on 11 April 1945.

15 Aug 1944

Registered at Buchenwald, delivered by the SD Den Haag. The cards record "Polizeibeamter", Protestant, married with 5 children, hard of hearing, missing teeth, height 179. He is placed in the overcrowded "Little Camp", block 59 according to the camp records (Hoekstra says 58), weighing about 65 kg. Hoekstra writes "Geert vond een plaats in barak 58" (Hoekstra 2013, p. 10). His Buchenwald labour card has an unlabelled "59" in the top-right box (Arolsen 6004391). The camp's own change report settles it in favour of 59: "Weimar-Buchenwald, 22. August 1944. Nachtrag zur Veränderungsmeldung vom 15.8.44. Namentliche Aufstellung der -159- Neuzugänge im Block 59" lists "5892 Greydanus, Geert" (Arolsen 5283423, in Veränderungsmeldungen Part VIII, Aug 1944, ref. 8012577). Hoekstra's "58" may be a slip, or a later move that is not recorded here. His Arolsen prisoner form records "Verhaftet am: 20.4.1944 wo: Varsseveld", "Einweisende Dienststelle: SD den Haag", father "Bauer Jaakob G. wohnt in Blija", mother "Saakje geb. Hibma", wife "Jakobje geb. Pebesma", schooling "Volksschule 7 Kl.", and is signed "Greydanus Geert" (Arolsen 6004389). His prisoner card gives "Grund: Polit. Holländer", height 178 and "2 fehlen" for teeth (6004384, 6004385). The infirmary card gives 64 kg on arrival, "schwerhörig" and "Gebiss lückenhaft" (6004387)

SOURCE: Red Cross / Buchenwald cards B, A; Hoekstra 2013, pp. 9–10

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4 Sep 1944

Transferred to Niederorschel ("Langenwerke AG") with a group of exactly 100 men who set up the camp. The only other Dutchman in the group is Jan (Johannes) Schepen of Joure. They work 12-hour days, 6 days a week. This fits the museum's account: "In September 1944, the SS established a satellite camp of the Buchenwald concentration camp in Niederorschel", with "several hundred prisoners" following in October (Museum Zwangsarbeit). Fenves came on one of those October transports (USHMM). Arolsen cards: "4.9.44 Niederorschel" (6004386); labour card "Beruf: Polizist" and "KDO. 4/9 No" (6004391)

SOURCE: Buchenwald card B ("4.9.44 Niederorschel"); Hoekstra 2013, pp. 10–12; Niederorschel (Stiftung Gedenkstätten)

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6 Oct 1944

His youngest son Bernhard (Ben) is born in Rotterdam

SOURCE: Pension decision 1967; Hoekstra 2013, p. 5

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19 Nov 1944

Leo Palache, 18, reaches Buchenwald from Auschwitz, registered as "Izak Palache, 20.1.1923", no. 95755, "Pol. Holl. Jude", "Schlosser". Weeks earlier his parents had been murdered in Auschwitz (18 Oct 1944) after Westerbork and Theresienstadt. The 2020 Yad Vashem proposal cites the Niederorschel museum's records that "Leo arrived on 30-31 October 1944", which matches the handwritten "30.10.44 Niederorschel" on his Buchenwald card. So he probably went to Niederorschel first and was registered in Buchenwald's books on 19 Nov. There he joins Geert, Schepen and the other Dutch Jews Geert later counted ("1 Hollander, niet-jood en 4 Holl. joden")

SOURCE: Arolsen 01010503 001.376.098; Joods Monument; Greydanus 2b

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Oct 1944 – Mar 1945

Paid in camp scrip: Langenwerke canteen vouchers (one stamped 17 XI 1944) and SS-Standort-Kantine Buchenwald tokens, all kept in the journal. Ben recalls a secret radio built from scraps that picked up the BBC, and ecumenical services that later felt like the closest Geert ever came to God. Ben's story of prisoners smuggling weapon parts and planning to rise up is independently confirmed by fellow prisoner Steven Fenves. Asked how many were making weapons, Fenves says "150 out of 700, something like that"; the guards were "40 - 50". He also says "we had counterfeit keys to all of the guards' rooms" and that "lot of people wanted to stage an uprising" when the camp was evacuated on 1 April (Fenves transcript, pp. 102–103)

SOURCE: Geert journal 15, 15b, 16, 17; Ben interview

Late 1944 (poster undated)

Back in Rotterdam, a German order calls up all men aged 17–40 for labour. Joel's essay says Jacob hid in the crawl space Geert had built under the stairs

SOURCE: Geert journal 39 + translation; Joel essay

1–10 Apr 1945

Death march from Niederorschel to Buchenwald, starting the night of Easter Sunday (1 April). Kapo Otto Herrmann slows the column. Over 100 of the 525 who set out die. The Thuringian forced-labour museum puts it at 527: "Only 425 of them arrived nine days later; the fate of the remaining prisoners is unknown" (Museum Zwangsarbeit, Niederorschel). A fellow marcher, Steven (Joska) Fenves, describes the march day by day in his USHMM oral history; see The death march. Ben says Geert and another prisoner carried Leo Palache so he would not be shot

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 13–14; Ben interview; Niederorschel PDF

1–10 Apr 1945 (family account)

Linda Walinga, Wietske's daughter, gives her mother's account: "Mother said that in Pake's barracks in Buchenwald there were three from the Netherlands, Pake, Leo Palache and another man also a political prisoner who was a Roman Catholic. She could not remember the man's name, and possibly never knew it. It could well be this unidentified man. In everyday life a Protestant, a Jew and a Catholic probably had little interaction, Holland was very much divided, sociologically speaking, along religious lines, but in Buchenwald they were united by language and stuck together. It was during the death march toward the end of the war that both Pake and the other man urged Leo Palache on, dragged him along, thereby saving his life."

The Catholic is very likely Johannes Anton Schepen: his Buchenwald card (Arolsen 7027532) gives "Rel.: rk" (Roman Catholic) and "Häftl. Art: Niederl.", and Geert's own 1945 form names "1 Hollander, niet-jood" with him in Niederorschel. The 3 May 1945 note lists the same three: Greydanus, Schepen, Palache. (Mother's "barracks in Buchenwald" would be the Niederorschel subcamp, run from Buchenwald)

SOURCE: Linda Walinga, statement to Jared, Nov 2026 (from Wietske Walinga-Greydanus); Arolsen 7027532; Greydanus 2b

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11 Apr 1945

Buchenwald liberated by US forces. On 24 Apr 1945 he signs that he has received his property back in full: "Umseitig bezeichnetes Eigentum habe ich am 24. APR. 1945 restlos zurückerhalten" (Arolsen effects card 6004388)

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport; Hoekstra 2013, p. 15

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3 May 1945

A Buchenwald investigation note lists 1. Greydanus, 2. Schepen, 3. Palache, which confirms the three were together. They are Geert (no. 5892), Johannes Anton Schepen of Joure/Groningen (no. 76773) and Leo (Isaac Leo) Palache of Amsterdam (no. 95755, registered as "Izak")

SOURCE: Geert journal 15; Context doc; Leo Palache (Times of Israel)

8–9 May 1945

Reaches the Veemgebouw evacuation centre in Eindhoven. On 9 May he sends a Red Cross message to Johanna: "Am well and healthy. Know nothing of the family. Was in Buchenwald. Hope to be home soon." The Eindhoven police certify him "fully reliable as to his political attitude"

SOURCE: Geert journal 18, 19, 20a

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11 May 1945

The Amsterdam paper De Vrije Katheder prints a "Namenlijst van ex-politieke gevangenen, meest uit Buchenwald" (list of ex-political prisoners, mostly from Buchenwald), so families would know who had survived. It includes "Geert Greydanus, Rotterdam" (the scan's text reads "Geert Greydanus P 'Rotterdam.") and, in the next column, "Johannes Schepen, Groningen." The first public notice that he was alive

SOURCE: De Vrije Katheder, 11 May 1945 (Delpher ddd:010448593); PDF copy in the archive

The death march: Niederorschel to Buchenwald, April 1945

WATCH: A FELLOW PRISONER ON THE SAME MARCH

Oral history interview with Steven Fenves

United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, RG-50.030.0494, recorded 25 March 2005, interviewer Joan Ringelheim. Nine tapes; Niederorschel and the march are on tapes 6 and 7. Fenves was 13 when he arrived at Niederorschel in October 1944 and walked the whole march with Geert's column.

Video and catalog record · Full transcript (PDF), pp. 95–112 · Fenves biography (USHMM)

Geert spent seven months at Niederorschel and left it on the death march of 1–10 April 1945. No one in the family papers describes the march beyond the account that Geert and another prisoner carried Leo Palache. Steven (Joska) Fenves, a Hungarian-Yugoslav Jewish boy from Subotica, was in the same camp and the same column and later described both in detail. The account below follows his interview, with page numbers from the USHMM transcript.

The camp

- **The work.** About 700 prisoners and 50 or 60 German civilians built aircraft wings on an assembly line: "12 hour work shifts, six and a half days a week. Every 30 minutes the bell rings and the wing moves up" (p. 98). Fenves worked on the inspection line, checking rivets with a dentist's mirror. By January the railway had been bombed, parts ran short and finished wings were piled in the snow (p. 100).

- **The kapo.** The two kapos were German communists imprisoned since 1933. Fenves could not recall the senior kapo's surname (Hoekstra names him as Otto Herrmann) but credits him with the camp's low death toll: "only 19 people died there" (pp. 96, 100–101).
- **Life in the barracks.** Shoemakers re-soled shoes with tyre rubber; tailors mended clothes with thread bought from the civilians; jewellers carved boxes from scrap aluminium to trade. Grown men held half-hour classes in algebra and French for the boys after the 12-hour shift. Sunday afternoons were free, and the prisoners sang (pp. 98–99, 109).
- **Weapons and a planned uprising.** Prisoners smuggled scrap metal out of the plant and ground it into knives at night; about a hundred Soviet POWs practised knife-throwing. Locksmiths among the prisoners copied the guards' keys from impressions in chewed bread. Asked how many were making weapons, Fenves says "150 out of 700, something like that", against 40–50 guards, mostly Wehrmacht reservists "in their 40's and 50's and 60's" under SS officers (pp. 99, 102–103).

Evacuation, 1 April 1945

On Easter Sunday, 1 April, the whistle went just after the 12-hour shift ended. In the kapos' room there was a vote on whether to rise up; the Czech labour orderly and Fenves voted no and swung it, because no one knew where the American front was. The kapo told the work-gang leaders that anyone was free to escape if he could, the cook handed out emergency rations (chicory, molasses), and the column marched out with their knives in their boots (pp. 102–105).

Ten days on the road

- **Distance.** About 120–150 km to Buchenwald, ten days on foot (p. 106).
- **Killing on the road.** "Escapes almost every night, shootings ... People falling behind shot and left ... dead in the gutter." Farmers watched from their fields holding pitchforks; townspeople looked out from behind lace curtains (p. 106). This is the danger Geert and the other prisoner were saving Leo Palache from.
- **The column.** Guards walked alongside. Behind came an old army truck carrying the relief guards and rolls of barbed wire, which were set up around the prisoners every night, and a First World War field kitchen that rarely worked (p. 106).

- **The route.** Through Sondershausen ("Sonderheim" in the transcript), the only large town, which had been bombed (p. 106).
- **Fenves's injury.** When he answered back, a guard swung his rifle at him and broke his arm. A Russian officer cut branches for a splint and he marched on with it (pp. 110–111).

Berlstedt: "stall"

"After eight days we arrived at another satellite camp called Berlsteed" (Berlstedt), a brickworks that supplied Buchenwald. SS guards from Buchenwald came by truck and took over from the Wehrmacht guards. With them was a prisoner in the red triangle and red beret of the Buchenwald camp resistance. Fenves crept up to him and was told: "Whatever you do, stall. Buchenwald is being emptied", with Jewish prisoners being taken away in open railway cars (p. 107).

Now that Buchenwald had a head count, the SS had to deliver that many prisoners, dead or alive. So three men hid in the brick kilns overnight. In the morning the count was three short, and the prisoners stood at attention for most of the day while guards searched. The SS lieutenant threatened to start shooting. Fenves expected the Soviet POWs to rush the few remaining guards with their knives. Then gunfire was heard from the west for the first time, and the SS marched the column out (pp. 107–108).

Arrival at Buchenwald, 10 April

The last stretch was the steep climb to the camp. To lift the silent, shuffling column, Fenves started a Russian song; the Russians took it up, then the whole column sang its way up the hill (pp. 108–109). At the gate the crematorium chimney was cold, and they were met by political prisoners in red berets: "On that day there were no more transports out, there were no more SS inside the camp, and the resistance organization controlled the camp." They were put in a barracks to sleep. The next afternoon, 11 April, someone shook Fenves awake to say the Americans had arrived (p. 109). His USHMM biography gives the dates: "On the night of April 1-2, 1945, the inmates were led out on a death march" and "They entered Buchenwald late on April 10" (USHMM).

Fenves gives no count of the dead on the march. The Thuringian forced-labour museum says 527 set out and "only 425 of them arrived nine days later" (Museum Zwangsarbeit); Hoekstra gives 525, of whom more than 100 died (Hoekstra 2013, pp. 13–14).

Geert and Leo Palache in the interview

- **Neither is named.** The interview names no Dutch political prisoner, no policeman and no Palache. The only prisoners from the Netherlands Fenves mentions are "two brothers, Hungarian Jews deported from Holland, diamond grinders by trade" who ground spectacle lenses from milk-bottle bottoms (p. 98). They are not Leo, who was born in Amsterdam.
- **What it confirms.** That Geert's column was marched for ten days, held each night inside barbed wire, and that those who fell behind were shot. That is the setting of the family account that Geert and another Dutchman, very likely Schepen, dragged Leo along (see the timeline, 1–10 Apr 1945).
- **Where it differs from the records.** Fenves says the plant made Messerschmitt wings; the camp records and his own USHMM biography say Junkers (see conflicts). He says the camp started in spring 1944; the museum and Geert's card date its founding to September 1944 (p. 100; Arolsen 6004386). And he recalls that "the French, Norwegians, Danes, Dutch, Belgians were out of there in 48 hours" after liberation (p. 112), but Geert was still in Buchenwald on 24 April, when he signed for his property (Arolsen 6004388), and reached Eindhoven on 8 May.

May 1945 – September 1947: back in Rotterdam

Geert was reinstated as "majoor" at the Centrale Recherche from 14 May 1945, with his pay and rights restored for the whole period he was away. But he was bitter about how the force treated him, and by September 1947 he had resigned and emigrated.

11–15 May 1945

Ordered by the Eindhoven police to Utrecht and the surrounding area on duty (12–14 or 15 May). Hoekstra has him arriving home in Rotterdam on 12 May, "unrecognisable", with missing teeth and clothes in rags

SOURCE: Geert journal 20b, 21; Hoekstra 2013, p. 16

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14 May 1945

Returns to police service. Pay and rights are restored (*rechtsherstel*) for 10 Apr 1943 – 14 May 1945

SOURCE: Police letter 26 Sep 1952

After liberation

Collects his sons from Friesland unannounced; Jerry recalls "he just showed up". Wietske, on her hunger trip back from Friesland, reads in an old newspaper in Amsterdam that her father is home

SOURCE: Ben interview (Jerry); Context doc; 30ff translation

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20 May 1945

Reports to the designated former-resistance authorities

SOURCE: Geert form p. 4, section VII

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25 May 1945

An Allied Expeditionary Force Civil Affairs pass lets him travel from Rotterdam to Friesland, Overijssel, Gelderland and Limburg for "essential police duties"

SOURCE: Geert journal 22

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26 May 1945

Rotterdam police statement: out of service 9 Apr 1943 – 14 May 1945, the last 9 months in Buchenwald, "now again employed in his function of Major at the Central Recherche"

SOURCE: Geert journal 20c + translation

Summer 1945

Writes to Jaap Stigter's parents, then visits them with his wife. The family's account (brother-in-law R.M. Eising, 2002) spells the name "Greidanus": "Gedurende de zomer van 1945 kregen we een brief van de heer Greidanus uit Rotterdam." It calls him a Rotterdam policeman arrested for refusing to arrest Jews, who met Jaap in Vught and "is later naar Duitsland vervoerd maar heeft de oorlog overleefd." They then met him on a Saturday afternoon that summer. He told them Jaap had been "tot grote steun" (a great support) to him and the other prisoners. In the evenings the prisoners could apparently talk quietly with one another, which the family could not explain, and "Als wij te bedroefd waren dan bad Jaap voor hen allen" (when we were too downcast, Jaap prayed for them all), and for "koningin en vaderland" (queen and country). This is the only known account of Geert describing his time in Vught to people outside the family. Identification as Geert: very likely, though not confirmed by name (see the spelling note)

SOURCE: NMK Vught: Stigter, Jacob

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12 Aug 1945

Gives statements about his captivity to the Netherlands Red Cross in Rotterdam (date from the 2015 family timeline). The Red Cross later summarised them: arrested in Varsseveld, hiding with "mr. H. Satter because he was policeman that had refused to arrest Jews on April 9, 1943"; Buchenwald from 15 Aug 1944, number 5892; Niederorschel 5 Sep 1944 to 1 or 2 Apr 1945; "He returned to the Netherlands on May 5, 1945." For Hendrik Satter the Red Cross only had "confirmation of his captivity in Siegburg Prison, August 31, 1944 to May 1945"

SOURCE: Red Cross letter in the Geert Greydanus Timeline doc

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12 Aug 1945 (his own words)

The original two-page form, signed "G. Greydanus", Rotterdam, 12 Aug 1945, stamped by the Afwikkelingsbureau Concentratiekampen. Arrested "Varsseveld ten huize van H. SATTER op 20-4-1944", "Als ondergedoken politieman. (Had op 9-4-43 geweigerd, Joden te arresteeren", by "S.D. ARNHEM". Arrested with him: "Hendrik Satter ±60 j. landbouwer te Varsseveld en Anne Schaap, ±25 j. onderwijzer te Varsseveld". On the march: "Op Zondag (1e Paaschdag) 1945 werd het Lager opgebroken in verband m.h. oprukken der geall. Voetreis door Thüringen, zeer veel moeilijkheden. Op 10-4-1945 terug in Buchenwald en op 11-4-45 aldaar door de geall. bevrijd."

His list of fellow prisoners who died: "Willem Rohaan ±30 j. landb. Neede"; "Heynen (drukker v. 'Trouw') Eibergen"; "Lebbeveld [?] ±55 j. Lichtenvoorde"; "een Marechaussee uit Neede (herinner mij naam niet)", with "Blauwgeers" added above; "de Marechaussee Paul[?] ±22 j. Varsseveld"; "de onderwijzer Th.C. van Braak Varsseveld"; "[2] politiemannen uit Nijmegen (Marcusse en [?])"; "Gerrit v.d. Bogaard ±30 j. candidaat-notaris"; "Gebr. (...?) waarvan een jarig op 1 Juni, eigenaar hotel en een bioscope te (Wageningen?)"; "Jaap Stigter, 19 j. uit het Westland (ondergedoken ...)"; "J. Berlijn ±42 j. koopman Rotterdam"; "J. Westerweel ±45 j. onderw. Montessorischool". Transported elsewhere: a "Secr. Ambt. (Haren Gr.)" who "was ±3½ week mijn celgenoot", and "Zekere 'Karel' van cel naast 93" (a certain 'Karel' from the cell next to 93)

And: "De fam. Rohaan – Heynen – v. Braak en Berlijn zijn door mij persoonlijk bezocht. [Ook heb] ik fam. van J. Stigter ontmoet." (I personally visited the families Rohaan, Heynen, v. Braak and Berlijn, and met the family of J. Stigter.) This is Geert's own confirmation of the Stigter visit recorded by the Kamp Vught museum

SOURCE: Greydanus 1a, Greydanus 1b (RedCross folder)

1945 (Stichting form)

Application for extra food to the Stichting 1940–'45, Bureau Ex-Politieke Gevangenen, Amsterdam (no. 7694, stamped "Geen dossier"). Born "1-12-1899 Cubaard (Friesl.)"; arrested "20-4-44 Varsseveld"; reason: "Was op 9-4-43 ondergedoken omdat hij als politieambtenaar geen joden wilde arresteeren"; returned "9-5-45". Camps: "Vught (bunker) van 21-4-44 tot 9-8-44. Aankomst Buchenwald 15-8-44. Op 5-9-44 naar een 'Buitencommando'. Dit was vliegtuigfabr. te Niederorschel (Thüringen). Op 1 of 2 April '45 terug naar Buchenwald. Daar op 10-4-45 gearriveerd en op 11-4-'45 bevrijd." Fellow prisoners: "In Niederorschel met 1 Hollander, niet-jood en 4 Holl. joden. Van deze is de ±50-jarige jood Akker uit Leeuwarden, tijdens de tocht van Niederorschel naar Buchenwald, overleden. Anderen allen terug." Need help? "Neen"

SOURCE: Greydanus 2a, Greydanus 2b

1945–1946

Struggles for recognition. His request for the extra rations due to camp survivors is on file with the Afwikkelingsbureau Concentratiekampen, which records "date of arrest: April 20, 1944", "camps: Vught, Buchenwald" and "reason for arrest: refuse to arrest Jews" (English as displayed; the original Dutch wording is not yet checked) (NIOD 250m inv. 67e, Goett – Green). Hoekstra says such requests went unanswered, and it is hard to get back the belongings taken in Vught. He is asked to sign a statement that he "refused service" or was insubordinate, which he refuses. Officers who collaborated get only a two-week suspension with pay

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 16–17; Ben interview; Joel essay; Hoekstra Yad Vashem report

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1947

Signs the restoration form in Rotterdam on 8 May 1947, listing his hiding places, his cover name and the support payments. Section III ends "Van 20-4-'44 tot 7-5-45, gevangene in Vught-Crefeld-Buchenwald"

SOURCE: Geert form pp. 1–6

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21 Aug 1947

His son Jacob (Jaap), conscripted for the Dutch East Indies, is shot within about 10 days of arriving, in a confused firefight between Dutch soldiers in Pasuruan. He is buried in the Surabaya war cemetery. Not until 1953 does the consulate tell the family it was friendly fire. War Graves Foundation: rank "Dpl. Sold. 3-4-5-RI", buried at Kembang Kuning war cemetery, Surabaya, grave B/119; visitors have added death notices from the Gereformeerd Jongelingsblad (26 Sep 1947) and the battalion paper Onder de Klapper (30 Aug 1947)

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 18; Ben interview

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8 Sep 1947

The family sails for Canada without Jacob, on the *Tabinta*, the second emigrant ship after the war

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 18; Joel essay

16 Sep 1947

Honourably discharged from the Rotterdam police at his own request, because of the emigration

SOURCE: Police letter 26 Sep 1952

1947–1967: Canada

At 47, Geert started over as a sponsored farm labourer in Ontario. The family moved about 13 times before he bought a farm near Clinton. A Dutch resistance pension was granted in 1959, backdated to 1947. He died of stomach cancer in 1965.

21 Sep 1947

Arrives in Canada. Works for farmer Dalton Snyder in Baden, Ont., with long days and no days off. Wietske earns $2 a day in the kitchen

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 18; Joel essay

c. 1948

Chest pains are diagnosed as serious, then a later doctor finds him "healthy as a horse". Ben calls it a stress episode that set the family back

SOURCE: Ben interview

End Mar 1948

Moves to chicken farmer Berkenshaw in Ridgetown

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 18

8 May 1948

On the eve of their 25th anniversary, a storm brings part of the roof in. Next the family goes to a tomato grower in Ridgetown, then to a rented house near Dresden, Ont.

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 19; Joel essay

27 Aug 1948

Applies to the Buitengewone Pensioenraad for a special resistance pension (received 14 Sep 1948), while living at R.R. 3, Dresden

SOURCE: Pension decision 26 Aug 1959; Verzetsrapport

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27 Nov 1948

Wietske marries Dirk Walinga; they live with her parents to share the rent

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 19

1950

Moves to a house outside Chatham. Cor has been to 6 schools in a short time

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 19

Sep–Oct 1952

For his pension file, the Stichting 1940–1945 collects statements from the Rotterdam police (26 Sep), J. Satters (26 Sep) and W.E. Braak-Raterink (6 Oct). Satters blames "many unpleasant things in Rotterdam" for the move to Canada

SOURCE: Verzetsrapport & stukken; English translations

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13 Jan 1953

The Stichting 1940–1945 issues its statement confirming his resistance service

SOURCE: Pension decision 26 Aug 1959

1953–1955

Buys a farm near Clinton, Ont. (Ben says 1953, about the 13th move; Hoekstra says 1955)

SOURCE: Ben interview; Hoekstra 2013, p. 19

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26 Aug 1959

Pension granted at 80% invalidity: f 3,600 a year plus f 900, backdated to 1 Oct 1947

SOURCE: Pension decision

1959

Uses the lump sum for a three-month trip to the Netherlands. He visits the Satter family and Leo Palache, then 33. Hendrik Satter himself had died on 16 Oct 1949 (Oorlogsgravenstichting); Hoekstra quotes Wil Satter remembering the visit and Geert's red-lined Canadian jacket, and on one train gets off rather than share it with a man he felt betrayed him

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 19; Ben interview

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24 Dec 1959

Passport stamped in New York (from the passport, per the 2015 family timeline). Possibly on the way to Tijuana for cancer treatment; no other source confirms this

SOURCE: Geert Greydanus Timeline doc (passport, family papers)

1950s

Offers to sponsor Johanna's cousin Jacoba Hoekstra-Baron's family for emigration (they did not come). Serves rotating terms as a church elder

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 19–20; Ben interview

1960 – Nov 1964

Health declines from 1960; stomach cancer is diagnosed in Nov 1964. He flies alone to a clinic in Mexico, and the couple leaves the farm for rented rooms in Clinton

SOURCE: Letter to Stichting 1940–1945, 1965

1965

Sells the farm for $6,500 and returns to Mexico in May with Johanna. He writes: "Until now never any pain"

SOURCE: Overige stukken

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14 Sep 1965

Dies in Clinton, Ont. He and Johanna are buried there

SOURCE: Pension decision 23 Mar 1967; Hoekstra Yad Vashem report; Hoekstra 2013, p. 20

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23 Mar 1967

Widow's pension granted to Jacobje Greydanus-Pebesma (f 2,274 a year) and to Bernhard (f 683), from 15 Sep 1965

SOURCE: Pension decision

People in Geert's story

Hendrik Satter (1885–1949)

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Farmer near Sinderen/Varsseveld who hid Geert. Arrested with him on 20 Apr 1944, later held at Siegburg; died in 1949 from the effects of the camps. Born Haaften 1 Aug 1885, died Doetinchem 16 Oct 1949 (Oorlogsbronnen)

SOURCE: Oorlogsgravenstichting; Hoekstra 2013, pp. 4–8, 17

J. (Jo) Satter(s), Wil Satter

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Hendrik's son, who handled pilots and wrote the 1952 statement, and his daughter. Wil was engaged to Anne Schaap. Willemien Satter: born Haaften 7 Mar 1922, died 12 May 2019 (Oorlogsbronnen)

SOURCE: Satter letter; Hoekstra 2013

Anne (Ane) Schaap

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Arrested with Geert, but played dumb and was released after 16 days. Known as "de Jodenman" (Trouw 2014). Born Leeuwarden 8 Jul 1919; listed in the Gedenkboek Verzetsherdenkingskruis (Documentatiegroep 40-45, ID 16507). His account is in NIOD archive 251a

SOURCE: Schaap account; NIOD scans

Theo van Braak

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Varsseveld teacher. Helped pilots with Geert in March 1944, was on the same transport, and died in Germany. Theodoor Christiaan van Braak, born Wisch 14 Apr 1898, teacher. Oorlogsbronnen: arrested in Varsseveld 1 May 1944, died Striegau 31 Dec 1944. Het Grote Gebod necrology: "Braak T. Ch. van Wisch 483 46 g. onderwijzer N.H. o. 31.12.44 Gross Rosen". His Vught card (Arolsen 342011) reads "Ziek geweest / Cel 93 / Bunker" with the date 19 8 44, the same cell 93 the Red Cross gives for Geert from early July 1944

SOURCE: Braak-Raterink letter; train note; Ben interview

Willy Markus

CONNECTION TO GEERT: SD agent provocateur whose betrayal led to the 20 Apr 1944 arrests

SOURCE: Wikipedia NL; Verzetsrapport

Gerrit J. van den Boogerd ("Oom Gert")

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Reserve officer who led the Achterhoek military resistance group around Lintvelde/Borculo. He took Willy Marcus (alias Willy van Erp) into his confidence in January 1944, and was arrested in Zutphen early on 20 April 1944, the day of Geert's arrest. Het Grote Gebod necrology: "Boogerd G. J. v. d. Zwartewaal 481. 482 35 g. 2 candidaat notaris N.H. e. 25. 7.44 Fort Rijnauwen", i.e. executed 25 Jul 1944 at Fort Rijnauwen. Not Geert, but shares the "Oom Gert" name

SOURCE: Het Grote Gebod I, pp. 481–484; NMK Vught: Stigter

Willem A. Rohaan, Teunis K. Wortman, Hendrik Kruizinga

CONNECTION TO GEERT: KP contacts listed in Het Grote Gebod (Rohaan and Kruizinga as "Contact KP"). The 2015 family notes: Rohaan was arrested on 5 May 1944, taken via Arnhem to Vught, sentenced on 2 Jun and shot on 6 Jun 1944 with Wortman and Kruizinga. Their names appear on Geert's Red Cross documents, per the same notes. TracesOfWar gives Rohaan as born "October 26th, 1912 (Neede)", died "June 6th, 1944 (Overveen, gemeente Bloemendaal)", so he may be one of the "anderen uit Neede" in the bunker. Het Grote Gebod II necrology: "Rohaan W. A. Neede 483 31 o. landbouwer N.H. e. 6. 6.44 Overveen"; "Kruizinga H. Neede 483 21 o. manufacturier Ger. e. 6. 6.44 Overveen"; "Wortman T. K. Geldermalsen 481 32 g. 1 marechaussee N.H. e. 6. 6.44 Overveen"; and "Heinen H. P. Eibergen 481 29 g. 2 drukker-fotograaf Ger. e. 6. 6.44 Overveen", probably the husband of the "Mevrouw Heinen" in the v.d. Hauw letter. It also confirms Jo Blaauwgeers's alias "Gert" (KP-Aalten, "arrested in Lichtenvoorde on 20 April 1944")

SOURCE: Het Grote Gebod I, pp. 481–482; 2015 timeline doc; TracesOfWar: Rohaan, Blaauwgeers (the Erebegraafplaats Bloemendaal links now return 404)

Jacob (Jaap) Stigter

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Born 23 Jul 1924, Honselersdijk. Refused labour service in 1943, went into hiding in Neede and joined KP-Neede. Wounded on a weapons raid, he was arrested on the road with the doctor treating him. Held in Vught alongside Geert and shot there on 9 Aug 1944, aged 20. Geert wrote to his parents in summer 1945 and visited them with his wife. The family learned of the death through their advertisement in Trouw, after which Ds. P. van Hoven brought the news

SOURCE: NMK Vught: Stigter, Jacob (R.M. Eising, 9 Dec 2002)

Jo Blaauwgeers

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Royal Marechaussee and LO helper, arrested the same day at Lichtenvoorde and executed on 6 Jun 1944. Father of Herma-Jozé Blaauwgeers, author of *Freedom is not free*

SOURCE: Jo Blaauwgeers; Schaap account

Jan (Johannes) Schepen

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Electrician from Joure, the only other Dutchman in Geert's Niederorschel group. Arolsen Buchenwald file 01010503 001.446.278 (10 documents): "SCHEPEN Johannes, 9.11.1899 Joure", no. 76773, "Polit. Holländer", eingewiesen 22.8.44; first names "Johannes Anton"; born "Joure Prov. Friesland"; last address apparently Groningen (handwriting not fully legible); religion "rk" (Roman Catholic). Almost certainly the unnamed Catholic who, in Wietske's account (via Linda Walinga), helped Geert drag Leo Palache along on the death march

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 10–12; Context doc

Isaac (Izak) Leo Palache, known as Leo

CONNECTION TO GEERT:

Jewish prisoner whom Geert helped carry on the death march (Ben's account); visited in 1959. According to Jared, a submission to Yad Vashem about this was not accepted for lack of evidence; that file is not among the Drive papers. Steven Fenves's transcript (all 144 pages) does not name him. Geert's own 1945 form says that in Niederorschel he was "met 1 Hollander, niet-jood en 4 Holl. joden" and that, apart from Akker of Leeuwarden, "Anderen allen terug".

Leo Palache is Isaac Leo Palache (Amsterdam, 20 Jan 1926 – Amsterdam, 9 Aug 1996), youngest son of Prof. Jehuda (Juda) Lion Palache, professor of Semitic languages at the University of Amsterdam, and Sophia Wilhelmina de Pinto. The Joods Monument lists him as a survivor; his parents, brother Mozes Herman and sister Judith Anna were murdered. The family address in Feb 1941 was Schubertstraat 52, Amsterdam. His father went Westerbork → Theresienstadt on 26 Feb 1944 (transport XXIV/4) and Theresienstadt → Auschwitz on 16 Oct 1944 (transport Er) (holocaust.cz); Wikipedia says the parents were murdered in Auschwitz on 18 Oct 1944 and "Leo" survived. Leo gave a USC Shoah Foundation testimony (VHA 4503, 22 Aug 1995, 1 h 54 min) whose index lists Westerbork, Auschwitz II-Birkenau, **Niederorschel** and **Buchenwald**, liberated by US forces at Buchenwald: the same subcamp and march as Geert.

The Buchenwald file for "PALACHE Izak, 20.1.1923" (Arolsen 01010503 001.376.098: no. 95755, "Pol. Holl. Jude", from Auschwitz 19 Nov 1944, "Schlosser"; one card has a handwritten note ending "Niederorschel") is almost certainly him: same first name (Izak = Isaac), same day and month of birth, and the right transport after the family reached Auschwitz in mid-October 1944. The birth year 1923 instead of 1926 (age 21 instead of 18) and the trade "locksmith" look like the kind of details young prisoners gave to seem fit for work. The birthplace on the cards reads "Leiden" or "Leider"; his real birthplace was Amsterdam. He is the "Palache" of the 3 May 1945 note.

Family account (Linda Walinga): Wietske said the three Dutchmen in Geert's barracks were Geert, Leo Palache and a Roman Catholic political prisoner whose name she didn't know, and that "both Pake and the other man urged Leo Palache on, dragged him along, thereby saving his life." The Catholic is very likely Johannes Anton Schepen ("Rel.: rk", Arolsen 7027532). This agrees with Ben's account of Geert helping Leo on the march. Both come from within the family, so they are not fully independent.

2020 Yad Vashem proposal (Jurjen Hoekstra with Ben Greydanus, Jenny Krabbe and Jared Dijkstra, Renkum, 1 Sep 2020; sources/YadVashem_JeroensVersion.pdf): "When Leo was at the point of collapse, he was helped by Geert G., together with another Dutchman. Had he not been helped, Leo Palache would for sure have died." It quotes Leo's Shoah Foundation interview on his condition during the march: "I understand your question .... Apparently not that bad, otherwise I would have been lying by the side of the road. Yes ... injured feet, dried out, dragging ... but I

completed the march." This is the only excerpt of his testimony found so far, and it comes via the proposal's translation. The proposal also says Leo "went to Rotterdam where he was active in the Jewish community" and that Geert "visited Leo P. in Rotterdam"; the Joods Monument gives Amsterdam as his place of death.

SOURCE: Ben interview; Times of Israel

J. Berlijn

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Geert lists "J. Berlijn ±42 j. koopman Rotterdam" among fellow prisoners who died, and says he personally visited the Berlijn family after the war. His first hiding place in April 1943 was "ten huize van M. Berlijn" in Rotterdam. The same family is likely, though the records don't say so outright

SOURCE: Greydanus 1b; 1947 restoration form

Akker (Leeuwarden)

CONNECTION TO GEERT: "de ±50-jarige jood Akker uit Leeuwarden", one of the four Dutch Jews with Geert in Niederorschel, who died on the march back to Buchenwald. The other Dutch prisoners all returned

SOURCE: Greydanus 2b

Otto Herrmann

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Communist kapo at Niederorschel who slowed the death march; later recognised by Yad Vashem

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, pp. 12–15

Jurjen and Jeltje Baron; Lammert and Romkje Baron

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Johanna's uncles and aunts in Suawoude. They sheltered Leni de Beer and another Jewish woman, and took in Jacob and Jan after Vught

SOURCE: Hoekstra Yad Vashem report; Hoekstra 2013

Leni de Beer

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Jewish teacher from Rotterdam who hid in Suawoude. Hoekstra suspects Geert helped her get there

SOURCE: Hoekstra Yad Vashem report

Peter Dijkstra

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Rotterdam policeman and Geert's brother-in-law, who carried messages for the family

SOURCE: Ben interview; journal 4b

H.A. Rauter, A. Seyss-Inquart

CONNECTION TO GEERT: Rauter ordered the release of the police families at Christmas 1943. The family appealed to Seyss-Inquart in June 1944

SOURCE: Rauter note; Seyss-Inquart letter

Conflicts and uncertain readings

Where the sources disagree, the timeline follows the contemporary official records (police letters, camp cards, pension decisions) over later memories.

; NIOD 251a inv. 20, scan 140

Cover name "de Boer Gerrit"

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Checked by eye on the scan, the handwriting reads "de Boer Gerrit geb. 1-9-97 te Leeuwarden". The Stichting's typed report also has "Oom Gerrit" where Satters' handwritten letter has "Oom Geert". No other record of a "Gerrit de Boer" born 1-9-1897 in Leeuwarden has been found. The places searched were Drive full text, the family papers and PDFs in the archive, Arolsen, the NIOD catalogue, Oorlogsbronnen and the web. So far the name appears only on Geert's own form. *Interpretation, not a source:* the alias stays close to his real identity. Gerrit is the Dutch form of Geert, Leeuwarden is the main town near his Frisian birthplace, and the day "1" is kept from his birth date. That would make it easy to remember under questioning. Still to check: the LO/LKP records (NIOD 251a) for a false identity card issued in that name

SOURCE: Geert form p. 4

When did the family's detention happen?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: The Vught hostage cards settle it: "Binnengekomen: 2 Dec. 1943", "Vrijgelaten 18 Dec. 1943" (Arolsen 360367, 360364). That fits Hoekstra (taken 1 Dec, released "vlak voor de Kerstdagen"), the Vught letters of 7–15 Dec, and Rauter's Christmas release. Satter's 1952 letter says they were held "including a newborn baby" and released after a Himmler visit. That fits neither: Ben was not born until 6 Oct 1944

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 6; Satter letter

Arrest date: 4 or 20 April 1944?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: The Red Cross summary says "arrested April 4, 1944 by the German secret police in Varsseveld". Every other source (Verzetsrapport, Schaap, Hoekstra, Het Grote Gebod's 20 April round-up) gives 20 April. Most likely a slip in the Red Cross letter. Settled: Geert's own Red Cross form says "op 20-4-1944" and his Stichting form says "20-4-44 Varsseveld"

SOURCE: Red Cross letter; Het Grote Gebod I, p. 484

Return date: 5 or 8 May 1945?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: The Red Cross says he "returned to the Netherlands on May 5, 1945". The Eindhoven reception records put him at the Veemgebouw on 8–9 May. Both can be true if he crossed the border on 5 May and was registered in Eindhoven days later. On his own Stichting form Geert gives "9-5-45" as the date he returned

SOURCE: Red Cross letter; Eindhoven certificate (see May 1945 section)

How badly was he mistreated?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: In August 1945 Geert played it down. Asked about mistreatment, he wrote "Slechts ten opzichte van mij zelf. Deze zijn echter niet van dien aard geweest dat ik hiervan (lichamelijk) langen tijd last heb ondervonden" (only towards myself; but not such that I suffered from it physically for long), and asked whether he needed help: "Neen". The later Verzetsrapport, Hoekstra and Ben describe severe beatings, and his pension claim rests on lasting damage. The family's view (Jared): he played it down out of misguided humility; the family understood that he was tortured

SOURCE: Greydanus 1a, 2b; Verzetsrapport

Errors in the 2020 Yad Vashem proposal

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: The proposal is a valuable summary but has slips that a resubmission should fix: "Geert Greydanus died in 1962" (he died 14 Sep 1965); "Lenie de Boer" once for Leni de Beer; Niederorschel made "plywood parts" for Junkers (Fenves says Messerschmitt wings); it says Leo "was send first, the rest of his family some time later", but his father went Westerbork → Theresienstadt → Auschwitz (Oct 1944) and the documents for Leo's own route are not yet in hand; and it calls Anne Schaap the "son-in-law of farmer Satter" (he was Wil Satter's fiancé in 1944). Its central claims match the records: the 9 Apr 1943 refusal, hiding with Satter, the Vught torture, Niederorschel and the march

SOURCE: YadVashem_JeroensVersion.pdf (Downloads); pension decision 1967; Fenves transcript p. 99; Trouw 2014

Did Hendrik Satter survive?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Brayard writes that Van der Hooft, "Satter and his father" were arrested and "Only Satter would survive", meaning Jo. The Red Cross confirms Hendrik's captivity in Siegburg until May 1945, and the Oorlogsgravenstichting gives his death as 16 Oct 1949. So the father survived the war but died of its effects; Brayard's "only Satter would survive" fits only Van der Hooft's death. Brayard also names Jo, not Anne Schaap, as arrested with his father; the Verzetsrapport and Schaap name Hendrik, Geert and Schaap. Van Kaam's 1995 Trouw article settles the first point from Jo Satter himself: "My father, who later died from the consequences of the concentration camp". It also shows Van der Hooft was arrested separately, on a train in mid-April 1944

SOURCE: Brayard 2000, p. 163; Red Cross letter

When did he go to Buchenwald?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: He left Vught on 9 Aug 1944, was held in the prison at Kleve, and was registered at Buchenwald on 15 Aug 1944. His 1945 Red Cross form ("per trein naar Cleef"), a Vught letter ("ik meen naar Kleef"), Hendrik Satter's account ("Greydanus was also in Kleve") and the Buchenwald effects card ("Die Eff. v. Haftanst. Kleve", Arolsen 6004388) all name Kleve; only his 1947 restoration form has "Crefeld". Joel's essay dates the move to December, which is incorrect

SOURCE: Buchenwald cards; journal 14b; Joel essay

What happened to Hendrik Satter?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Ben recalls Satter dying under interrogation. The Oorlogsgravenstichting, Schaap and Hoekstra all show he survived Siegburg and died in 1949

SOURCE: Ben interview; Oorlogsgravenstichting

What did Niederorschel make?

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Hoekstra says Focke-Wulf; the Thuringian memorial foundation says Junkers wing and landing-gear parts, and the forced-labour museum says "the facility was immediately tasked with manufacturing aircraft parts for the Junkers Group" (Museum Zwangsarbeit). Fenves too worked "on the assembly line in a Junkers aircraft factory" (USHMM). Ben recalls a "munitions factory"

SOURCE: Hoekstra 2013, p. 11; Stiftung Gedenkstätten

Rank

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Records variously call him agent, brigadier and "majoor" of the Centrale Recherche. The 1959 pension decision says he was promoted to brigadier before 29 Sep 1947

SOURCE: Pension decision 1959; 20c translation

Clinton farm purchase

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: 1953 (Ben) or 1955 (Hoekstra)

SOURCE: See the Canada section

Wife's name

WHAT THE SOURCES SAY: Legally Jacobje Pebesma (born 22 Apr 1902); called Johanna in the family

SOURCE: Pension decision 1967

Additional sources and where to look next

Key reference: Nationaal Monument Kamp Vught, "Jacob Stigter". These are the memories of Jaap Stigter's brother-in-law R.M. Eising, signed 9 Dec 2002. They are the only known outside account of what Geert said about Vught, and they confirm his post-war contact with a fellow prisoner's family. The name is spelled "Greidanus", but the man is described as a Rotterdam policeman arrested for refusing to arrest Jews, which identifies Geert. Leads it opens:

- Geert's summer-1945 letter, which may survive with Stigter or Eising descendants.
- The family's post-liberation advertisement in *Trouw* (search Delpher for "Stigter" in 1945).
- Ds. P. van Hoven, the minister who brought the news.

- KP-Neede and its members arrested in April–May 1944, the "anderen uit Neede" of the v.d. Hauw letter.
- The Vught *Sterbebuch* 1944 and the *Erelijst*, both cited by the museum.

Pseudonyms: exact wording

Only one source gives a cover name in Geert's own hand, and it is an official government form. The others are what people called him. Each is quoted exactly below, and only these quotations support a pseudonym in this timeline.

de Boer, Gerrit (cover name)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: Printed question: "V. dat hij tijdens de bezetting heeft geleefd onder de(n) volgende(n) schuilnaam (namen)". Handwritten answer: "de Boer Gerrit geb. 1-9-97 te Leeuwarden"

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Restoration form p. 4: "Formulier, bedoeld in artikel 2 van het Eerste Uitvoeringsbesluit Wet rechtsherstel Overheidspersoneel 1946", signed "G. Greydanus", Rotterdam, 8 May 1947 (p. 1, p. 5). An official government form, filled in by Geert himself

HOW SURE: High. Checked by eye on the scan; "Boer" is clear

"**Oom Geert**" (what the group called him)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: "Oom Geert" zoals Greijdanus genoemd werd was een illegale groep van Varsseveld in alles behulpzaam"

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: J. Satters letter, 26 Sep 1952 (handwritten original in the Verzetsrapport PDF; English translation). A private statement written for the Stichting's pension file

HOW SURE: High for the wording

"**Oom Gerrit**" (same nickname, different spelling)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: ""Oom Gerrit", zoals de heer Greydanus genoemd werd, heeft het verzet in de Achterhoek, grote diensten bewezen". The letters after "Ge" look over-typed

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Verzetsrapport, typed by the local board of the Stichting 1940–1945, Varsseveld (c. 1952). Semi-official

HOW SURE: Medium. It may be a typing correction, or it may echo the cover name Gerrit. The handwritten Satters letter says "Geert"

False police ID (no name given)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: "(Greydanus had een valsch P.B. Gemeentepolitie Rotterdam."

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Anne Schaap's account, NIOD 251a p. 7 (translation). A post-war resistance testimony

HOW SURE: Name not recorded

Other false papers (no names given)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: "He was given a revolver and three sets of identification so that he could travel". Asked whether he used a pseudonym: "No. No? No."

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Ben interview, 2025. Family memory

HOW SURE: Names not known

"Oom Geert" in *Freedom is not free*

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: The interviewer: "they mentioned this person like Oom Geert two times in the book and Jared thinks that that it could be Pake" (Frisian for grandpa, i.e. Geert). Jared's note: in earlier emails with him, the book's author (Herma-Jozé Blaauwgeers) disagreed that her "Oom Geert" is Geert Greydanus

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Ben interview. The book is a historical novel, so it is not independent evidence

HOW SURE: Unconfirmed; check the paper copy

"Oom Gert" (NOT Geert: Gerrit J. van den Boogerd)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: "Het hoofd en de ziel van deze groep was Oom Gert (Gerrit J. v.d. Boogerd †), reserveofficier van het veldleger." (p. 482). Also: "Door Oom Gert was in Januari '44 contact opgenomen met een man, die onder de naam Willy van Erp" (p. 482), and on 20 April "Het begint 's morgens al vroeg met de arrestatie van Oom Gert en Dick te Zutfen" (p. 484). In the same list Jo Blaauwgeers's alias is "(Gert)" (p. 481)

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Het Grote Gebod I, "De Achterhoek" (G.H. Ligterink), pp. 478–485. Published LO-LKP memorial book (1951), not an official record

HOW SURE: Certain that "Oom Gert" was van den Boogerd, leader of the Achterhoek military group who brought Willy Marcus in. This is a second "Uncle" with a near-identical name in the same district, arrested the same day. Any "Oom Gert(-rit)" in a source needs checking against both men. It may explain why the author of Freedom is not free does not read her "Oom Geert" as Greydanus; that is a possibility, not established

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"de Jodenman" (NOT Geert: Anne Schaap)

EXACT WORDING IN THE SOURCE: "Haar verloofde Anne Schaap kwam geregeld op de boerderij. Hij stond bekend als 'de Jodenman' en schrok er niet voor terug om gezochte mensen bij daglicht met de fiets naar andere adressen te brengen." (Her fiancé Anne Schaap came to the farm regularly. He was known as 'the Jew man' and did not shrink from taking wanted people to other addresses by bicycle in daylight.)

SOURCE AND ITS STANDING: Trouw, "Aan de wieg van een verzetskrant", 30 Jan 2014, Willemien Satter interviewed at 91. Newspaper retelling of an eyewitness, 71 years later

HOW SURE: A nickname by reputation, not a code name. It fits Schaap's work finding places for Jews in Hoekstra's account

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ISBN 90-77731-03-2

This is *Freedom is not free: the price was paid on D-Day* (a historical novel) by Herma-Jozé Blaauwgeers (listing). She is the daughter of Jo Blaauwgeers, who was arrested in the same 20 April 1944 sweep and loaded onto the same truck at Lichtenvoorde (Schaap account). He was executed on 6 June 1944 ("D-Day") (Jo Blaauwgeers). In Ben's interview, the interviewer says Jared found "Oom Geert" mentioned twice in it. No searchable text is online, so to confirm, check the paper copy for:

- "Oom Geert", "Oom Gerrit", "Geert", "Gerrit", "Greydanus", "de Boer", "rechercheur" or "politieman". Note the exact wording and page of any hit, because a novel may use real names or invented ones
- Scenes at the Satter farm in Sinderen, the truck to Avegoor and Arnhem on 20–21 April 1944, and the Vught bunker (April–June 1944)

How the Trouw article fits

The article ("Aan de wieg van een verzetskrant", Meindert van der Kaaij; dated c. 30 Jan 2014 from its line "Vandaag precies 71 jaar geleden") does not mention Geert. It does explain why the farm where he hid was so important, and it lines up with what the family papers say. This summary is from the copy on the family blog.

Jan 1943

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: Willemien Satter overhears the planning for Trouw at the farm in Sinderen

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: About three months before Geert arrived (late Apr 1943, form p. 1)

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30 Jan 1943

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: Trouw is officially founded in Aerdenhout, at Gezina van der Molen's home; the leadership then meets regularly at the Satter farm

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: Hoekstra says Geert was kept out of these meetings (p. 5). The Stichting report says "de heer Satter behoorde tot één van de medeoprichters van het illegale blad 'Trouw'" (Verzetsrapport)

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25 Mar 1943

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: Cor van der Hooft obtains SS officer Kurt Gerstein's report on the gassings; Trouw thus had the first report on the Holocaust

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: Before Geert arrived. The Context doc links two other Trouw articles on the Gerstein report and the Satters, and Hoekstra's appendix has a newspaper piece, "Van Sinderen naar Londen, de weg van een document" (Hoekstra 2013, pp. 21–23)

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25 Mar 1943 (Brayard)

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: Florent Brayard's article: "on March 25, 1943, Van der Hooft met with members of his underground network, Jo Satter and his father, in the outskirts of Doesburg", wrote a four-page report "Tötunsanstalten in Polen", and "The report was hidden in the chicken coop of the Satter farm. A year later, Van der Hooft was arrested, as well as Satter and his father. Only Satter would survive." Jo Satter kept it until he saw a Lou de Jong broadcast, and "Satter had died in 1988". Footnote 16 cites a letter from Henk Biersteker, 4 Nov 1996. Not about Geert, but it dates the Satters' arrest to about April 1944

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: Brayard, "An Early Report by Kurt Gerstein", Bulletin du CRFJ 6 (2000), pp. 157–174 (PDF copy in the archive, pp. 163–165)

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25 Mar 1943 (Van Kaam)

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: Ben van Kaam, from his January 1968 interview with Jo Satter, places the writing "in the farmhouse in Sinderen" (Brayard says the outskirts of Doesburg). Jo Satter is quoted: "I can still see Cor sitting there writing. ... My father, who later died from the consequences of the concentration camp, was there too." Van der Hooft was not arrested with the Satters: "In mid-April 1944, he was arrested on the train due to an error in his identity card", shot in the legs at Geldermalsen, later taken to Oranienburg, and shot by the SD days before liberation. Jo Satter found the document after the war under the roof tile, and sent it to Lou de Jong after seeing a rerun of De Bezetting on 22 Nov 1966. No mention of Greydanus. Quotes are from an English browser translation, not the Dutch original

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: Ben van Kaam, "De waarheid bleef liggen onder een dakpan", Trouw, 22 Jul 1995 (PDF printout in the archive, English translation)

Spring 1944

WHAT THE ARTICLE SAYS: (Not in the article)

HOW IT CONNECTS TO GEERT: Geert is ordered to work for the Trouw group in Friesland, about a week before his arrest (Verzetsrapport; Satters letter). Ben says the family's version, that he was "circulation director" of Trouw, may have been a cover story (Ben interview)

The article draws on the same eyewitness, Wil Satter, that Hoekstra interviewed for his 2013 life story. The two are not independent, but they agree.

Archives likely to hold more

From the links in the 2015 Geert Greydanus Timeline doc:

- Het Grote Gebod I, "De Achterhoek", G.H. Ligterink, pp. 478–485. It describes the Marcus betrayal and the 20 April 1944 round-up: "Zo breekt de 20ste April aan, de zwartste dag voor het Achterhoekse verzet." Raids that day hit Neede, Eibergen, Borculo, Lichtenvoorde, Varsseveld and Aalten, and "Een groot aantal gevangenen werd te Arnhem op transport gesteld naar Vught." It does not name Greydanus, Greidanus or Satter. "Oom Gert" here is Gerrit van den Boogerd (see the pseudonym table). The PDF linked in the 2015 timeline, pp. 465–477, is the Overijssel chapter; it has no Greydanus, Satter or "Oom Gert".
- NIOD 249-0225, "Executie Varsseveld". Three items on the reprisal shooting of 46 people at Varsseveld on 2 March 1945, after four Germans were killed. It is context for the Satters' village while Geert was in Niederorschel. Not digitised.

- NIOD 251a inv. 7, LO Friesland. 193 scans covering Suawoude, Tietjerksteradeel, Hennaarderadeel and others. NIOD's full-text search finds no Greydanus or Greidanus there, and "Suawoude Baron" returns nothing. The scans have not been read page by page.
- A NIOD search for "Satter" finds four archives: 214 (Siegburg and Rheinbach prison files, restricted, consult with the Director's permission), which likely holds Hendrik Satter's file; 250m; 020; and the KB I newspaper-clipping collection.
- jolink.org says the January 1943 meeting that created Trouw was "at Hendrik Satter's house in the hamlet Sinderen in Wisch", and that the first issue was "published on 1943 Jan 19". That date differs from the 30 Jan founding above. The first LO meeting was also held there. No mention of Greydanus.
- Joop Westerweel (Wikipedia): arrested 10 Mar 1944, executed in Vught 11 Aug 1944. No source yet links him to Geert.
- Not yet checked: the SGD 1961–1962 item on the Buchenwald package; the Rohaan and Blaauwgeers biographies (the site returns errors); *Trouw*, 4 Jun 1994, "40-DATA-45". The KB list of ex-political prisoners is the Delpher item ddd:010448593, *De Vrije Katheder* of 11 May 1945 (see May 1945). eindhoven4044.nl cites it as a source for Buchenwald political prisoners in radio lists (*Herrijzend Nederland*) and *De Waarheid*; that Eindhoven page has no Greydanus, Satter or Varsseveld. The SGD 1961–1962 identifier resolves to Tweede Kamer 6758 nr. 1, a 4 Jul 1962 naturalisation bill ("Naturalisatie van Gach, Jozef en 21 anderen"), probably not the Buchenwald item; the numbering may have changed since 2015.
  Oorlogsbronnen has a person record for "Geert Greijdanus", Hennaarderadeel 1 Dec 1899, linked to the Buchenwald records and to a War Graves Foundation entry, which now returns "Page not found". It also has records for Jacob, Wietske and Jacobje; Jacob's links to his War Graves Foundation page and to a Nationaal Archief personal file. Arolsen has no separate files for Jacob or Jan beyond the Vught hostage cards. Steven Fenves's transcript (all 144 pages) has no Palache, Greydanus or Dutch policeman. The only Dutch link in Niederorschel is "these two brothers, Hungarian Jews deported from Holland, diamond grinders by trade, who ground prescription glasses out of bottoms of discarded milk bottles" (p. 99), and he says the camp made "wings for Messerschmitt fighter planes". Fenves left Auschwitz in mid-October 1944. *De Vrije Katheder*, 11 May 1945 (Delpher), names "Geert Greydanus, Rotterdam" among returned prisoners.
- **NIOD (archieven.nl)**: a search for "Greydanus" (search) finds four things about Geert. Two are 251a inv. 20 scans 137–140 (the Schaap/Satter account and the arrest list). The others are a 1945 letter in 251a inv. 325 placing him in the Vught bunker, and his

request for extra food coupons in 250m inv. 67e. The remaining hits are other people: Prof. S. Greydanus, a Mrs Greydanus in Alkmaar, and an internee in Semarang.

- **Spelling "Greidanus"**: the traditional spelling, and far more common. Records may use it (the 1952 Stichting letters already use "Greijdanus"). A NIOD search for "Greidanus" (search) gives 12 archive results and 24 text hits. None is Geert or his household; "Greidanus Geert" returns nothing. They are other people: the Alkmaar KP family of Anna Maria Greidanus-Labberté ("Tante Maria", 853), her son Piet (arrested 26 Jun 1944, released 3 Jul 1944, 251a inv. 171/242/287/309) and daughter Ina (a courier), and A.J. Greidanus (Alkmaar, b. 1918; 250d, 197b). Also Karst Greidanus (Sneek, b. 1919; 197p, 250m) and seaman D.E.D. Greidanus (Heteren, b. 1922; 214, 250m). The rest are notary A. Greidanus of Harderwijk (182), J. and Johan Greidanus (191, KB I), Mrs. M.P. van Meerten-Greidanus (249-0172A), and internees in Semarang (401). Any future search in Arolsen, Oorlogsbronnen or Delpher should try Greydanus, Greijdanus and Greidanus.
  One "Greidanus" that is almost certainly Geert: the Kamp Vught museum page on Jacob Stigter. The family's 2002 recollection names "de heer Greidanus uit Rotterdam". The details fit Geert and no other known Greidanus: a Rotterdam policeman, arrested for refusing to arrest Jews, held in Vught with Stigter's KP-Neede group, sent on to Germany, survived, and visited with his wife. The v.d. Hauw letter (NIOD 251a inv. 325) independently puts "de anderen uit Neede" in the bunker cells beside Greydanus. Stigter was shot on 9 Aug 1944, the day Geert's transport left. Caveat: this is a secondhand memory written down 57 years later, and the spelling is the family's, not an official record.
  A "G. Greidanus" that is not Geert: NIOD archive 528, L.T. Boesten. Its introduction says Boesten's regiment, the 13th Infantry (13 RI), was "under the command of Lieutenant Colonel G. Greidanus" on the Peel Line in May 1940, with the regimental post in Zeeland (Noord-Brabant). The initial matches, but this is a career army officer commanding a regiment. In 1940 Geert was a Rotterdam police detective. Do not merge the two.
- **Arolsen Archives**: Geert's personal file exists: "Personal file of GREYDANUS, GEERT, born on 1-Dec-1899", ref. 01010503 001.163.120, 9 documents (DocIDs 6004383–6004391). The thumbnails include a registration form, index cards and orange effects cards marked 5892. All 9 have been read, and the details are quoted in the Buchenwald section: cover sheet (6004383), prisoner cards (6004384–6004385), Niederorschel index card (6004386), infirmary card (6004387), effects card (6004388), prisoner form (6004389), clerk's card (6004390) and labour card (6004391). Related files (Schepen,

Palache, Van Braak) can be searched from the Buchenwald individual documents (Arolsen finding aid).

- **NIOD, archive 251a (Stichting 1940–1945 / LO-LKP)**: the full Achterhoek report that Schaap's account came from (pages 0138–0140 are in Drive) (NIOD scans).
- **Netwerk Oorlogsbronnen**: national index of Dutch WWII collections; search "Greydanus" and "Greijdanus" (oorlogsbronnen.nl).
- **Willy Markus's post-war trial file (CABR, Nationaal Archief)**: may list the 20 April 1944 arrests by name (Willy Markus).
- **Niederorschel: memorial, museum and a fellow survivor**: the Museum Zwangsarbeit's Niederorschel history (founded September 1944; more than 700 prisoners; at least 19 died in the camp; 527 sent on the march, 425 arrived). Steven Fenves's USHMM oral history and First Person video describe the same camp and march first-hand; he is unrelated to Geert. The English transcript covers the evacuation and march on pp. 102–109 (of 144); Niederorschel itself comes just before; the remaining pages are worth searching for "Palache" and Dutch prisoners. Hoekstra also mentions a published Niederorschel book (Stiftung Gedenkstätten).
- **Klaas Baron's wartime memoir**: mentions "neef Geert" in Suawoude (Hoekstra 2013, p. 1).
- **Jared's research blog**: greydanus.blogspot.com.

Drive folders used

- Folder 1 (Stichting pension, Red Cross, translations, Ben interview)
- Greydanus/Walinga family papers: Context index, Geert journal, Geert form
- Jenny Krabbe photos: 1949 letters from Rotterdam friends to Wietske in Canada; nothing on Geert directly

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The Yad Vashem submission (2020)

On 1 September 2020 Jurjen Hoekstra, with Ben (Bernard) Greydanus, Jenny Krabbe and Jared Dijkstra, asked Yad Vashem to recognise Geert (sources/YadVashem_JeroensVersion.pdf, 4 pages, signed at Renkum). It rested on three points: the Leni de Beer hiding (likely but unproven, and not claimed as fact), his refusal on 9 April 1943 to arrest Jews and its cost, and his help to Leo Palache on the death march. It was not accepted for lack of evidence.

Errors in the proposal

- It says Geert died in 1962. He died on 14 September 1965.
- It calls Leni de Beer "Lenie de Boer" once.
- It calls Anne Schaap Satter's son-in-law. In 1944 he was Wil Satter's fiancé.
- It says Niederorschel made plywood parts for Junkers. Fenves says Messerschmitt wings.
- It says Leo was "send first" ahead of his family. His father's route was Westerbork → Theresienstadt → Auschwitz, and we don't yet have Leo's own transport records.
- It says Leo lived in Rotterdam and that Geert visited him there. The Joods Monument gives Amsterdam as the place he died.

Its central claims all match the records: the refusal on 9 April 1943, hiding with Satter, the torture in Vught, Niederorschel and the march.

Evidence found since the proposal

- **Geert's own 1945 forms** (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b) give the arrest reason in his own words: "Was op 9-4-43 ondergedoken omdat hij als politieambtenaar geen joden wilde arresteeren". They also name the Dutch group in Niederorschel: "1 Hollander, niet-jood en 4 Holl. joden".
- **The Buchenwald note of 3 May 1945** lists "1. Greydanus, 2. Schepen, 3. Palache", putting the three men together.
- **Leo Palache identified**: Isaac Leo Palache, born Amsterdam 20 Jan 1926, died Amsterdam 9 Aug 1996 (Joods Monument), registered in Buchenwald as "Izak Palache, 20.1.1923", no. 95755 (Arolsen). His card's "30.10.44 Niederorschel" matches the museum's "30-31 October 1944" cited in the proposal. His Shoah Foundation testimony (VHA 4503, 1995) is indexed for Niederorschel and Buchenwald.
- **The "other Dutchman" is Johannes Antonius (Anton) Schepen** (see below), the only non-Jewish Dutchman with Geert in Niederorschel, and a Catholic, as Wietske remembered.
- **Family accounts**: Ben's interview and Wietske's account via Linda Walinga both describe the rescue. They agree but are not independent of each other.

Johannes Antonius (Anton) Schepen, the third man

- Born Joure, Friesland, 9 Nov 1899; died 2 Oct 1984 (Oorlogsbronnen). Radio mechanic and works electrician ("Radiomechaniker, Betriebselektriker"); married to Maria Schepen-Stuivenberg[?]; home "Groningen, Rabenhauptstr. 22".
- Buchenwald no. 76773, "Polit. Holländer", registered 22 Aug 1944, a week after Geert; "kath. verh." (Catholic, married); height 179, weight 69 kg on arrival (Arolsen file, cards 7027532–7027535).
- His labour card reads "Langenwerke – Niederorschel" (Arolsen 7027539), the firm that ran the subcamp. His effects were returned on "30. 4. 1945" (7027535), just after liberation.
- The Groningen resistance card index (OVCG) holds a card for him: "The person concerned was imprisoned in Buchenwald, Nieder Orsel commando, number 76773, according to correspondence with Expogé from 1948 in which he complains of a defective right lung" (Oorlogsbronnen source). Expogé was the post-war association of ex-political prisoners, so that 1948 correspondence may describe Niederorschel and the march.
- De Vrije Katheder's list of returned prisoners on 11 May 1945 names "Johannes Schepen, Groningen" a few lines from "Geert Greydanus, Rotterdam".

The death march, as the sources now stand

- **Start**: "Op Zondag (1e Paaschdag) 1945 werd het Lager opgebroken" (Geert, 1945), i.e. Easter Sunday, 1 April 1945; 527 prisoners set out and 425 arrived (Museum Zwangsarbeit).
- **Route and conditions**: "Voetreis door Thüringen, zeer veel moeilijkheden" (Geert); via Sondershausen and Berlstedt, with shootings of stragglers (Fenves); delayed by kapo Otto Herrmann.
- **The Dutch group**: Geert, Schepen and four Dutch Jews, Leo among them. "Akker uit Leeuwarden", about 50, died on the way; "Anderen allen terug" (Geert, 1945).
- **Leo's condition, in his own words** (via the proposal): "injured feet, dried out, dragging … but I completed the march."
- **The rescue**: "both Pake and the other man urged Leo Palache on, dragged him along, thereby saving his life" (Wietske via Linda); "When Leo was at the point of collapse, he was helped by Geert G., together with another Dutchman" (2020 proposal).
- **Arrival and liberation**: Buchenwald on 10 April; liberated 11 April 1945.

To strengthen a resubmission

1. Obtain Leo Palache's full Shoah Foundation testimony and transcribe the march section, especially any mention of who helped him.
2. Ask the OVCG / Groninger Archieven for Schepen's full card and the 1948 Expogé correspondence, but do not look for descendants. Jurjen Hoekstra's notes say "He had no children" and "After the war museum in Niederorschel has been erected, Schepen was a guest of honour", so ask the museum for its file on him. The same notes say "In Niederorschel he has for a long time been very sick. He came from Joure Friesland" (Context doc). He died in 1984; his wife was Maria, of Groningen.
3. Ask the Niederorschel museum (Museum Zwangsarbeit) and the Buchenwald Memorial for the Niederorschel prisoner lists and any record of the Dutch group, including Akker of Leeuwarden.
4. Search Arolsen and the Joods Monument for the other three Dutch Jews and Akker, who may also have left testimony.
5. Correct the errors above and attach the 1945 forms, the 3 May 1945 note, the Arolsen cards for all three men and the family accounts.

Next steps

Every known avenue still open for the years in hiding and detention (April 1943 – May 1945). (Online) = can be searched now; (You) = needs you, a login or a paper copy; (Request) = needs a visit or a written request.

Priority actions

1. **Check *Freedom is not free* (ISBN 90-77731-03-2)** for its "Oom Geert" passages. If that person leads the group, meets Willy Marcus or is arrested in Zutphen, it is Gerrit van den Boogerd ("Oom Gert"), not Geert. This settles the cover-name question either way.
2. **Watch Leo Palache's 1995 USC Shoah Foundation testimony** (VHA 4503) for Geert or the march. It is available online after registration or at a VHA access site.
3. **Request Geert's Red Cross file** from the Nationaal Archief, which holds the Red Cross war archive. The family papers have his statements of 12 Aug 1945 (Greydanus 1a, 1b, 2a, 2b); the file may hold more on the arrest, the Vught cells and Kleve.

4. **Request Willy Markus's CABR files** at the Nationaal Archief: inventory 66972 (on paper, The Hague) and inventory 188 (scanned, digital CABR); see The betrayal: Willy Markus. Collaborator files often list everyone a traitor gave up, and may show what the SD knew about Geert on 20 April 1944.
5. **Trace Geert's summer-1945 letter to the Stigter family.** Try Stigter or Eising descendants around Honselersdijk and Naaldwijk, or ask the Kamp Vught museum, which received R.M. Eising's 2002 memories.
6. **Write to the Rotterdam Stadsarchief** for his police personnel file: the April 1943 dismissal, the May 1945 reinstatement and the 1947 discharge, and how the force recorded his going into hiding.
7. **Print Trouw, "40-DATA-45" (4 Jun 1994) to PDF** if it can be found on the Trouw site.

In hiding, April 1943 – 20 April 1944

- (You) **ISBN 90-77731-03-2, *Freedom is not free***: the Satter farm, the 20 April sweep and the bunker scenes. Check whether its "Oom Geert" fits Gerrit van den Boogerd ("Oom Gert") better than Geert.
- (Online) **NIOD 251a inv. 7 (LO Friesland)**: 193 scans covering Suawoude and Tietjerksteradeel, for the Friesland trip in spring 1944 and the Barons.
- (Online) **NIOD 251a, the rest of the Achterhoek LO-LKP report**: only scans 0138–0140 are in hand.
- (Online) **Delpher**: 1943–1944 newspapers for the Rotterdam dismissal notice; Trouw and other illegal papers for the Varsseveld group.
- (Request) **Rotterdam Stadsarchief**: police personnel records (dismissal 10 Apr 1943, the "de Boer Gerrit" cover, reinstatement, discharge).
- (Request) **Stichting 1940–1945 / Verzetsherdenkingskruis files**: Anne Schaap is in the Gedenkboek; Geert, Hendrik and Jo Satter may have files.
- (Online) **Documentatiegroep 40-45 database**: entries for Satter (ID 16496) and Schaap (16507); search it for Greydanus, Van Braak and Van den Boogerd.
- (You) **Theo van Braak's family**: the Braak-Raterink letter suggests contact; they may hold more on the March 1944 pilot work.
- (Online) **Allied airmen records** (Stichting Luchtoorlog Onderzoek Nederland, E&E reports): crews hidden near Varsseveld and Sinderen in March 1944 may name helpers.
- (Online) **Yad Vashem**: the Baron file (8067103) and Leni de Beer; check for any testimony naming a Rotterdam policeman.

Arrest, Vught and transport, 20 April – August 1944

- (Request) **Willy Markus's CABR files** (Nationaal Archief, inventory 66972 and 188): the 20 April 1944 arrest lists.
- (Request) **NIOD 214 (Siegburg prison files)**: restricted; likely Hendrik Satter's file.
- (Online) **Arolsen, Vught records**: Geert's own Herzogenbusch card, if any (cells 117 and 93); the cell-93 neighbours, starting with Theo van Braak.
- (Online) **NMK Vught**: the museum's own archive and Sterbebuch; the Jaap Stigter and KP-Neede prisoners.
- (You) **Stigter / Eising family**: Geert's summer-1945 letter to Jaap Stigter's parents.
- (You) **Trouw 1994 and 2014 originals**: "40-DATA-45" (4 Jun 1994) and "Aan de wieg van een verzetskrant" (2014), as PDFs in Downloads.

Buchenwald and Niederorschel, August 1944 – May 1945

- (Online) **Arolsen, Izak Palache (no. 95755)**: confirm the Niederorschel date and transfer; check whether family knew him as "Leo".
- (Online) **Arolsen, Johannes Schepen (no. 76773)**: the remaining 7 cards, for Niederorschel and the march.
- (Online) **Arolsen, Niederorschel transport and strength lists**: lists naming the Dutch group.
- (You) **Yad Vashem submission about Leo Palache**: the submission and the reply.
- (Request) **Museum Zwangsarbeit Niederorschel / Gedenkstätte Buchenwald**: prisoner lists for the Junkers subcamp and the April 1945 march.
- (Request) **Netherlands Red Cross war archive (now at the Nationaal Archief)**: Geert's 12 Aug 1945 statements in full (scans 1 and 2).

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